

found in the small Mutaqallabat Valley and in Ras el-Kharrubeh. The architecture of the round towers in Mutaqallabat, already mentioned, may indicate Ammonite elements there.

Most of the Iron Age II sites seems to have been founded during the 8th century BCE, the most prosperous period of northern Israel, yet some had already been founded in the time of the United Monarchy (Holladay 1966). Typical types of pottery are cooking pots of type D, the jars with ridges on the neck and the hole mouth jars with shelf rims. Typical 9th century vessels are rare.

The situation in the neighboring territories is somehow unclear.

The 44 sites dating to the “Israelite period, time of the kingdom” are just 13% of the total in the Beth Shean Valley (Zori 1962, 197). This low figure, compared to 31% in East Manasseh, is hard to explain. In Zori’s (1977, 152) study of Issachar, there are 60 sites of Iron Age II, close to our figures. A problem rises also in the results of Gal (1980, 104): only seven out of his 26 sites have Iron Age II pottery, and two of them are marked with parentheses indicating “very few finds”. This sharp decline requires an explanation. Ephraim (Finkelstein 1988-1989, 151-152) records a settlement peak similar to ours.



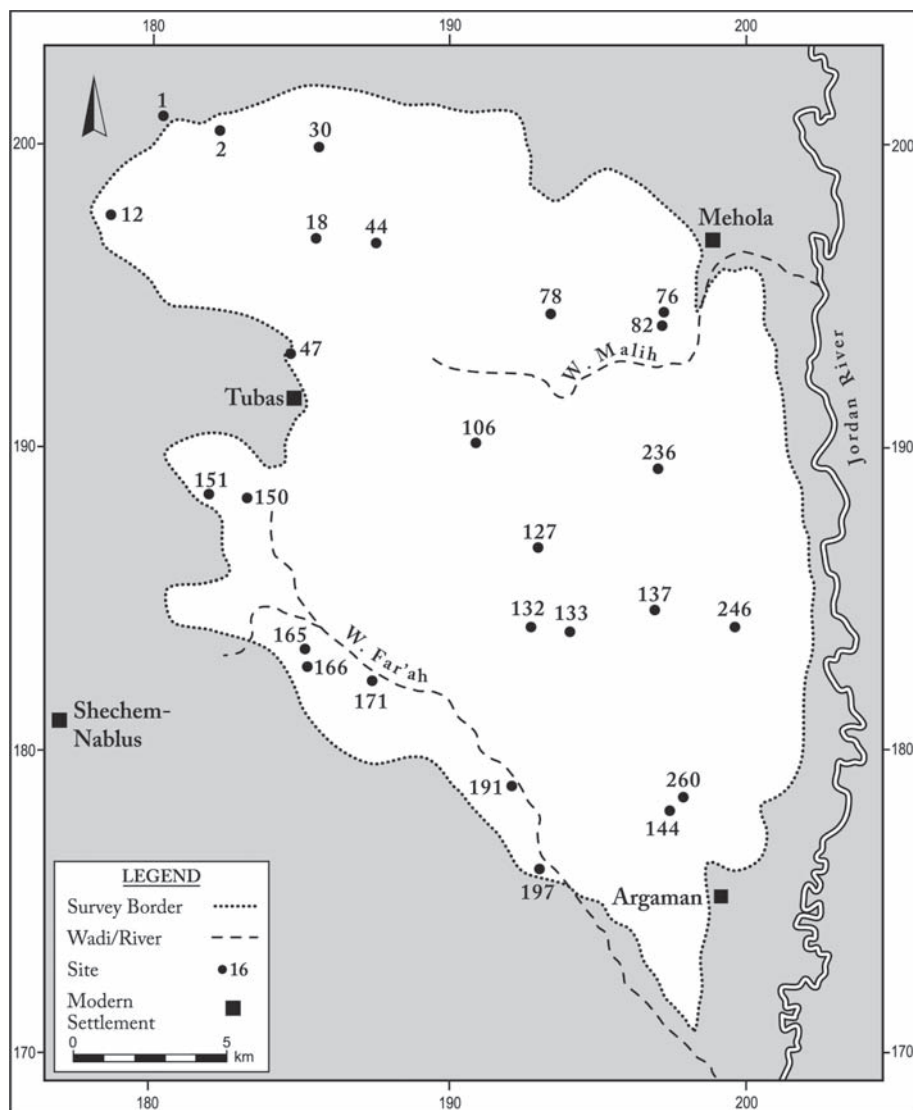
31. A scenery in the Desert Fringes.

9. Iron Age III (= IrA III, *The Assyrian Province*)

The definition of Iron Age III, not thoroughly discussed by scholars so far, is based upon historical circumstances and several pottery types. They consist of the “late” ridged-

necked jar, the hole mouth jar with the sharp shelf rim and, above all, the wedge-shaped decorated bowl (Zertal 1989b).

The 150 years which followed the fall of Samaria in 722-721 BCE saw a sharp decline in the settlement of East Manasseh, and only in 25 sites



32. Map of the Iron Age III sites.

this period is represented. It seems that this decline evolved from the Assyrian exile policy, which deeply affected this territory. The villages and farms in the arid zones were the first to be abandoned, and the population moved to the richer and better defended Mediterranean zones. However, even in the latter area there is a 50% decline of settlement (Zertal 2004, 57-59). The desertion of the east was apparently not quick, and no evidence of destruction or fire was found. Assyrian destruction is typical only of cities and tells (*cf.* Tel el-Far'ah, destroyed and fired – De Vaux 1992, 1301).

All the Iron Age III sites continued from Iron Age II. There are no new foundations and the population that continued was undoubtedly Israelite. On the other hand, the Assyrians settled the foreign populaces brought from Mesopotamia in the eastern valleys, as testified by the wedge-decorated bowls scatter. Four of the 25 sites are located in the Zebabdeh Valley and five in the Buqe'ah. Tubas Valley, with few Iron Age II sites, has just one Iron Age III settlement. Hence, the two former valleys represent 40% of the total Iron Age III sites. It seems that these concentrations were produced by populaces close in language, origin and material culture, which later created the Cu-thaeen community.

The above concentrations are

prominent when compared to other landscape units, which were almost entirely vacated during Iron Age III. These are Ras es-Salmeh, Wadi Malih, the Desert Fringes, *etc.*

In the neighboring areas no distinction of Iron Age III has been found.

10. Persian Period (the Jewish return to Zion)

The Persian period continues its predecessor in some characteristics, but in the Mediterranean area (the Shechem Syncline) there is unprecedented prosperity (Zertal 1989a). This is the result of the important status of Samaria as capital of northern Palestine, the accumulation of wealth resulting from the prosperous trade with the Phoenician ports and the entrance into the land of various populations: Israelites, Cu-thaeans, Ammonites, Moabites, *etc.* (*cf.* Lemaire 1994b).

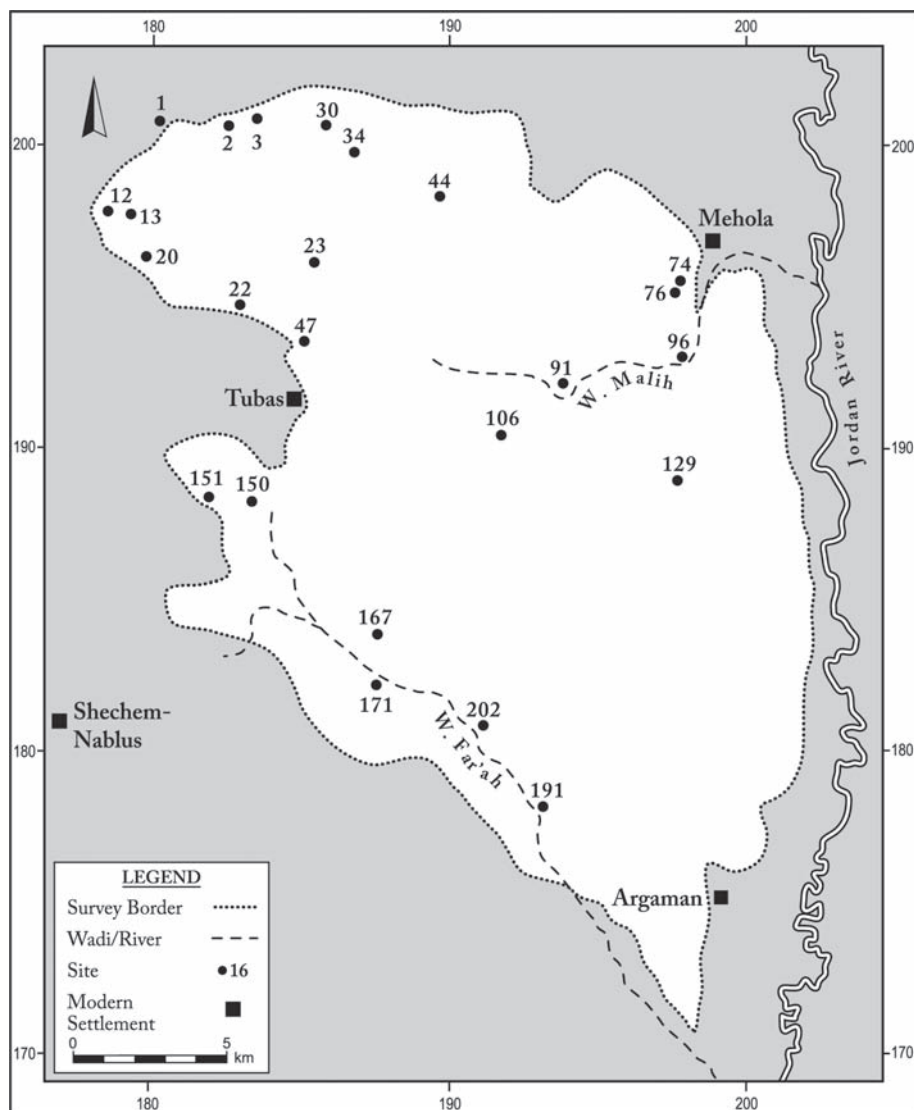
Yet East Manasseh does not take part in that prosperity, and its decline, brought about by the Assyrian rule, continues. Of the overall 23 sites from the Persian period, the 11 sites in the Zebabdeh Valley belong to the Mediterranean zone rather than to our semi arid lands. These relate, it seems, to the Dothan Valley and the region of Qabatiyeh, where crowded settlement is found in this period.

In the rest of East Manasseh, settlement is sporadic. A phenomenon

difficult to explain is the lack even of nomads and semi nomads, who were present in all other periods. Almost no Persian Period pottery was recorded in the nomadic encampments. In the units of Tubas Valley, the Buqei'ah, and the Desert Fringes there is no Persian Period

sites. There is, however, a presence in Kh. Yerzah as well as several sites in Wadi Malih.

As for the neighbors, in the Beth Shean Valley, 44 sites were registered (out of the total 321 sites in the survey - Zori 1962, 197), a figure equal to Iron Age II. In the Is-

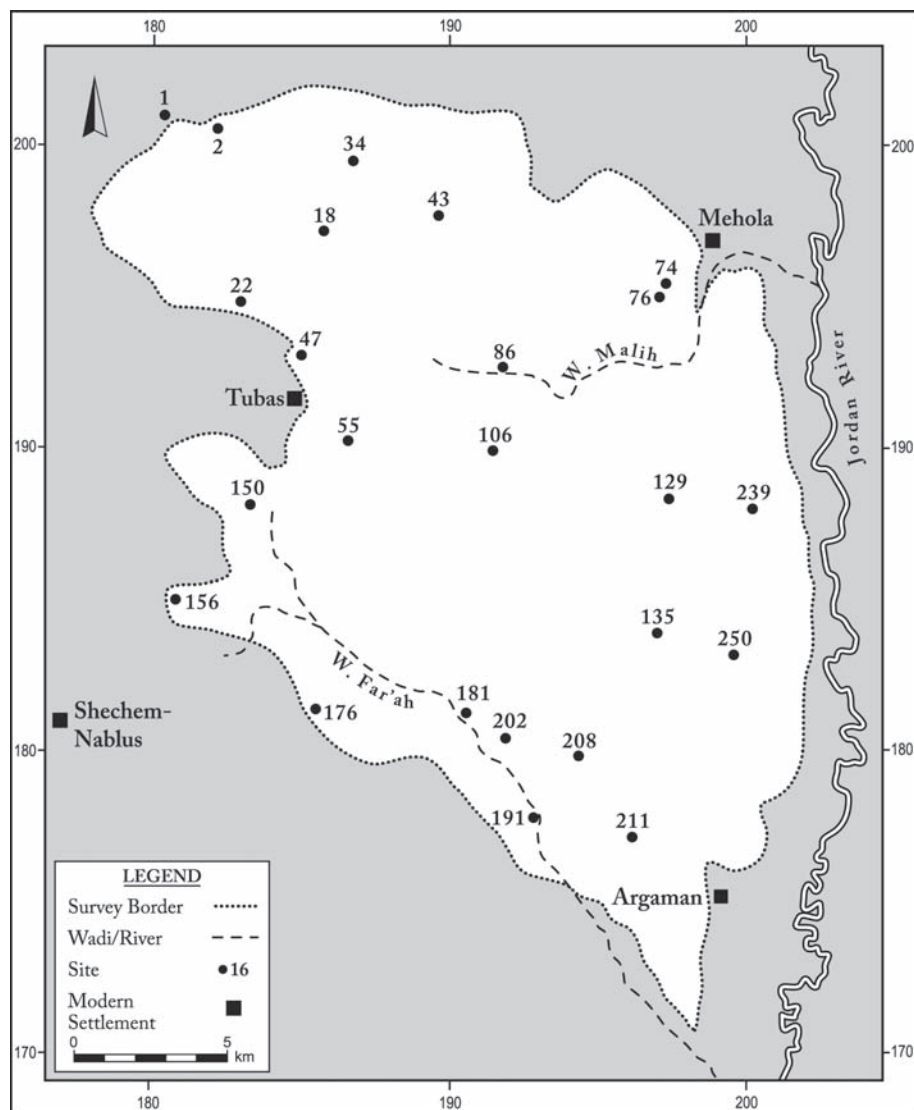


33. Map of the Persian Period sites.

sachar area of Zori (1977,152) the number rises to 73 sites. Ephraim shows a dramatic decline, though an analysis of its reasons is difficult to conduct due to lack of data.

11. Hellenistic Period (The rule of the Seleucids and Hasmonaeans)

During the Hellenistic period settlement remains sparse, with its 24 sites. The Shechem Syncline suffers severe events, related to the actions of Alexander the Great against the



34. Map of the Hellenistic Period sites.

Samaritans following his conquest (Zertal 2004, 60-61). This is based, among other reasons, on the assumption that in the end of the 4th century BCE the process of the "Samaritanization" of the population has been almost completed. Israelites, Judaeans, Cuthaeans and other populaces have assimilated and fused into the new Samaritan nation. The settlement of the Persian period in East Manasseh seems not to have been adversely affected by the Greeks, and 46% of the Persian Period sites continue into the Hellenistic period. These sites seem to be the basis for the ever growing settlement numbers from this point on and into the Roman and Byzantine periods.

It is suggested, as well, that East Manasseh did not suffer much from the campaigns of the Hasmonaean kings against Samaria in the end of the 2nd century BCE, either. John Hyrcanus I directed his campaign against the Samaritans around the capital of Samaria and the Samaritan cultic center that was built on top of the Samaritan Mount Garizim (ca. 112-108 BCE). The conquest of Samaria paved the way to the north and the Galilee, and the east was not crucial for these plans. The fortress on the high summit of Kh. Quleh (no. 43) indicates fortification of the road from Scythopolis to Neapolis and Samaria.

A similar decline is registered in the Beth Shean Valley and the Is-

sachar territory. In the former, Zori (1962, 197) records a decline of 41% vis-à-vis the Persian period, while in the latter (Zori 1977, 154) the number of sites declined by 45%. This, therefore, can be regarded as a general phenomenon.

In Ephraim the surveyors have scarcely made a division between the Persian and Hellenistic periods, and the whole period is regarded as "problematic" (Finkelstein 1988-1989, 155).

12. Early Roman Period (= ER, Herodian to the First Revolt)

Here the re-settlement of East Manasseh begins. The 35 sites of the period show a rise of 45% in comparison with the Hellenistic Period. Only 14 of the sites (40% of the total) continued from the above period, and the other 21 are newly founded. Moreover, all the Early Roman Period sites continue from now on.

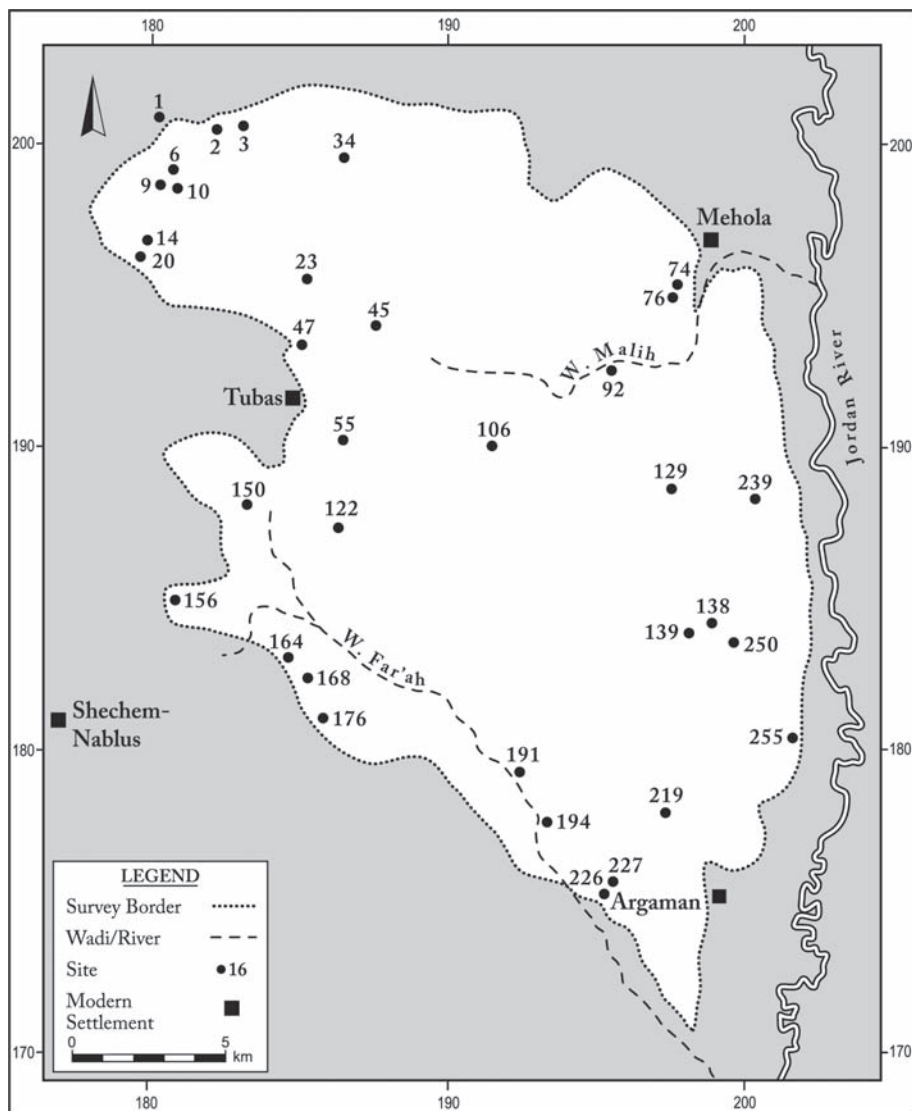
As for clusters, the Zebabdeh Valley has nine sites, seven of which are new; in Ras es-Salmeh, Tubas Valley and Ras Jadir the settlement is sparse (one or two sites per unit), and in the Buqei'ah, Wadi Malih and Ras Humsah there are three or four sites per unit. Most of the settlements are farms or small villages. A comparison with the Mediterranean zone shows different directions: while in the former the settle-

ment is stable, in East Manasseh it grows, presumably due to the fact that the area did not suffer during the Hellenistic Period.

In all the territory east of the city of Samaria, not a single new Greek *polis* developed. The territory was divided among Scythopolis, Sa-

maria and the cities of the Decapolis east of the Jordan.

In the Beth Shean Valley, Zori reports on seven "Roman" sites, an impossible figure, probably related to the difficulty of identifying the pottery. In the Issachar territory 71 "Roman" sites were identified,

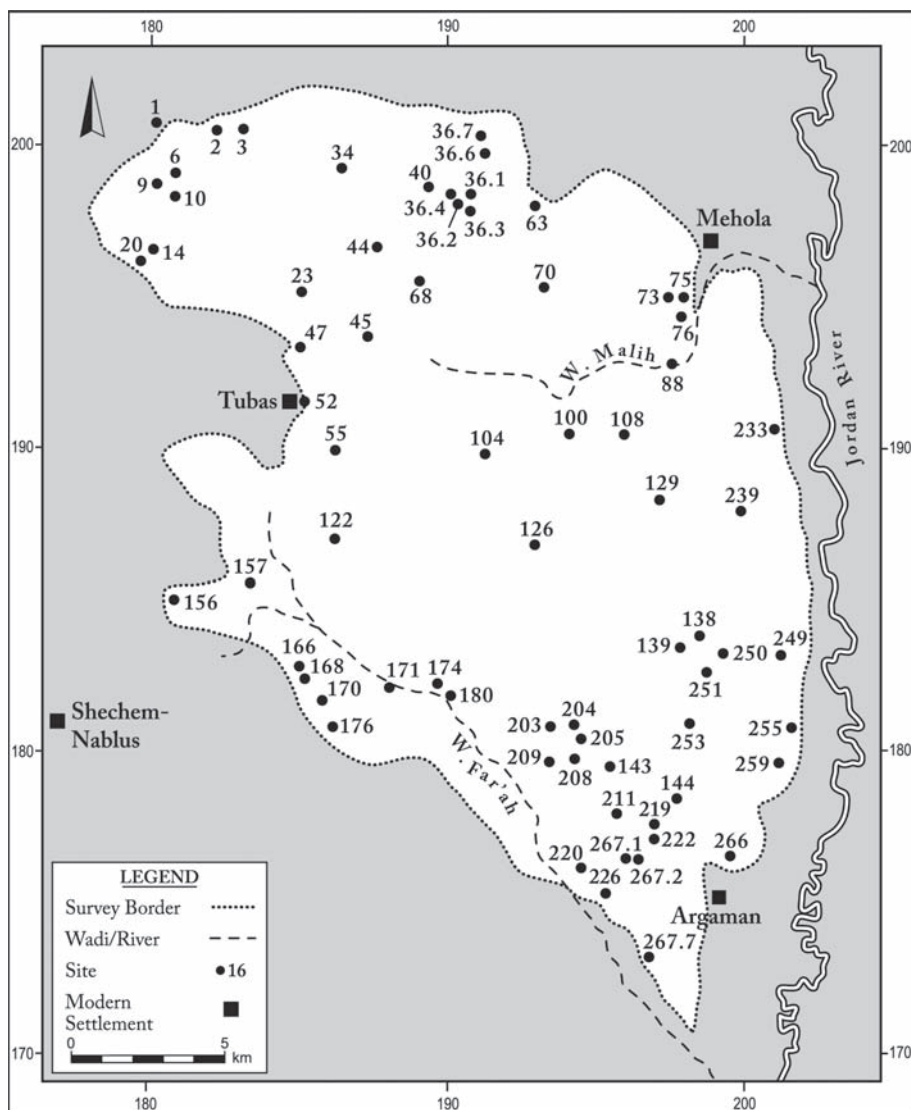


35. Map of the Early Roman Period sites.

77% more than in the Hellenistic Period. In Ephraim no distinction exists between Early and Late Roman Periods.

*13. Late Roman Period (= LR,
from the First Revolt to the
Constantines)*

This period saw the real “jump” in the number of settlements. The 70 Late Roman Period sites are almost equal in number to Iron Age II, and large sections of the landscape units were resettled. This is especially attested to in Ras es-Salmeh, Wadi Malih, the Buqe’ah and the Desert



36. Map of the Late Roman Period sites.

Fringes. More than half of the sites are new farms and villages. Unlike Juadea, severely damaged after the two Jewish revolts against the Romans, the Samaritan territories enjoyed a prospering economy and security. This is the possible background for the Roman military system here, founded with the support of the local population, which was sympathetic to the Romans.

In this period the first towns were founded, including Yerzah (A – no. 106), Umm el-‘Uqbeh (B – no. 114), Jabaris (no. 69), es-Samrah (no. 129), *etc.* They are all located east of the national watershed, in the hilly area of Ras Jadir and Wadi Malih. These were the relatively vacant areas in the former periods, where much unoccupied land awaited the settler. Cultivation became possible, as terracing and building of roads and dams created an impressive agricultural system. These systems are found in Ras es-Salmeh (especially in ‘Iraq el-Hamam – no. 36), east of Ras Jadir and the Buqeï‘ah. These new towns are not built in Wadi Far‘ah and the eastern valleys, because there water and land had been fully employed before.

In conclusion, the Late Roman Period period is the time of development and growth in East Manasseh. The two roadside fortresses in the Buqeï‘ah, Kh. Humsah (no. 143) and Kh. Umm Kharaz (no. 144) were both built in this period.

14. Byzantine Period (from the Constantines to the Arab Conquest)

This is the peak of settlement of all the periods. Byzantine Period pottery is registered in 144 sites, twice as many as in the preceding period. There are several aspects to this process: farms and villages grew up and became towns, and many new farms and villages founded. This pattern enabled the exploitation of each parcel of land: for growing grains, orchards (mainly olives) and animal husbandry. The pace of growth is equal here to that of the other regions, indicating organic development without external interference.

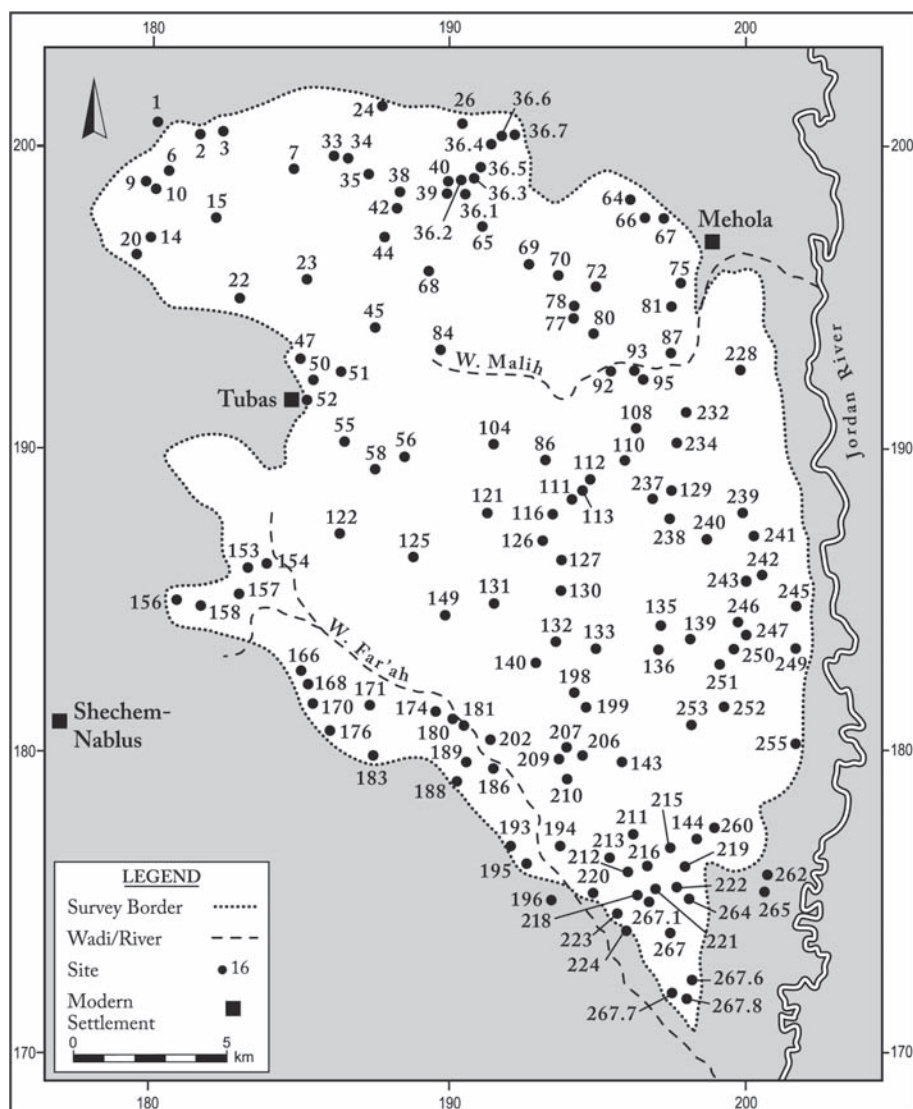
The ethnicity of the population here is not always certain, with the lack of historical texts, but some assumptions can be made. On the winepress in Kh. Ibziq (lower – no. 42) there are names of Jews or Samaritans, and most of the population must have been Christians, as is shown by the churches and monasteries.

In that period the Roman military system in the east seems to have been abandoned. Eusebius in his *Onomasticon* refers to four sites in the area (*Asher, Thebez, Bezzeq* and *Beth Meulah*), and the Map of Madabah does not refer to the area.

The towns and townlets here are at their maximal size: 10 to 60 du-

nam (2.5-15 acres) each, with 400 to 2500 inhabitants. These were the "backbone" of the territory, with the necessary services: markets, dwellings, inns, administration and religious places available to the population. It can be compared to the prosperous towns of the Negev

highlands (Shivta, Avdat, Haluzah, *etc.*), which were bigger in size and more closely related to trade and pilgrimage. Most of the 13 towns (*i.e.*, Ibbizq A-B, Jabaris, Haddad, Yarzah, Samrah, Mufiyeh, Muqey-simeh, Smeit, Farhan, 'Uqbah (A), Fukhar and Shaqq) are located in a



37. Map of the Byzantine Period sites.

long strip between Ras Jadir and the Desert Fringes. The 320 dunams (80 acres) of built up area of these towns and townlets were easily able to hold some 10.000 inhabitants.

The 50 villages (unfortified sites 2-10 dunams or 0.5-2.5 acres in area) seem to have developed from farmsteads. Together with the latter, these are the majority of the sites by number. Encampments are 10% of the total and a new feature is the square, well constructed courtyards, presumably built for cattle.

In the Shechem Syncline the Byzantine Period settlement is 47% of the total number of sites, *vs.* 53% in the east. The former was governed by the two large cities – Sebasteh and Neapolis. In Issachar, Zori (1977, 154) found Byzantine Period pottery in 70% of the total, while in Beth Shean it was 55%. In Ephraim 267 of the sites had this pottery, with only 5% of them in his “fringes of the desert”.

15. Early Moslem Period (= EM, the Umayyad, Fatimid and Abasside dynasties to the Crusader conquest)

The Early Moslem period, which lasted 460 years, saw a sharp decrease in settlement compared to the Byzantine period. Only in 55 sites pottery of the period was registered, a decline of two thirds compared to the previous period. This decline relates to the lower status

of Palestine in the imperial administration and the general neglect of the country. The wars between the new conquerors added to the overall decline, which can be determined through six points:

A. no foundation of new sites is registered;

B. the area of the remaining sites shrinks, which indicates shrinking of the population;

C. several regions are slowly abandoned, mostly the remote ones;

D. the towns are either abandoned or their area shrinks, while the farms are less abandoned than the towns (a phenomenon that needs further explanation);

E. the Jordan Valley becomes a center of economy, a development related to the entrance of the sugar cane as industrial agriculture (and *cf.* Zertal 2005, 79);

F. this seems to be the period when the present Arabic villages begin their existence (Tilfit, Zebabdeh, Kfer, Sir, 'Aqabah, Rabbah, Taiyasir, Tubas and Tammun); corresponding phenomenon appears in the Shechem Syncline.

It can be assumed that the general decline is connected, as well, to the fact that the capitals – Tiberias, capital of Jind Urdun, and Ramleh, capital of Jind Filastin – are both relatively far away from our region.

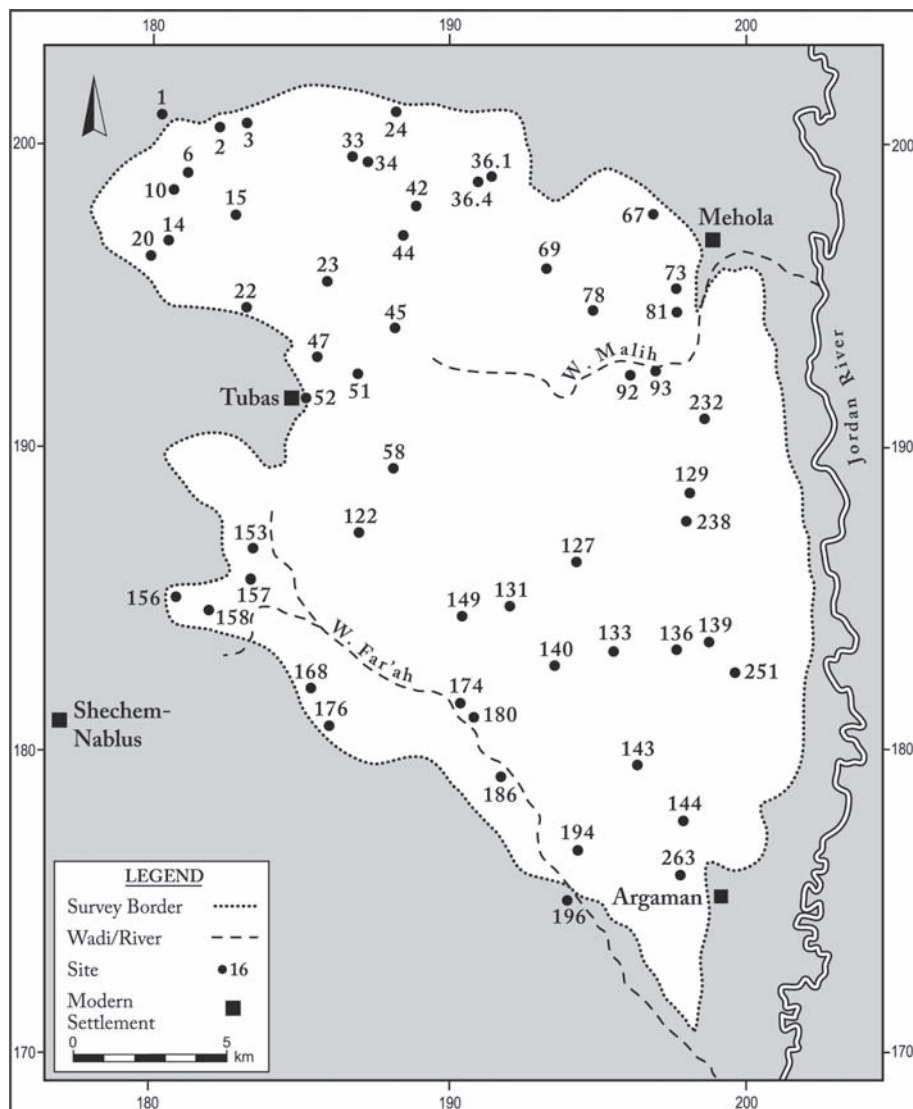
In the neighboring regions the picture is not very clear. In Issa-

char, Zori (1977, 154) reports 68 sites from the "early Arab period". This figure is 32% of the total, *vs.* 18% in East Manasseh. In the Beth Shean Valley there were 85 sites, or 48% of the total. Finkelstein (1988-1989, 161-163) indicates the problematic division between

the periods.

16. Middle Ages (= MA, the Crusader and Mameluk periods).

During this long period the settlement rises. The 69 sites of the period are 20% more in number than



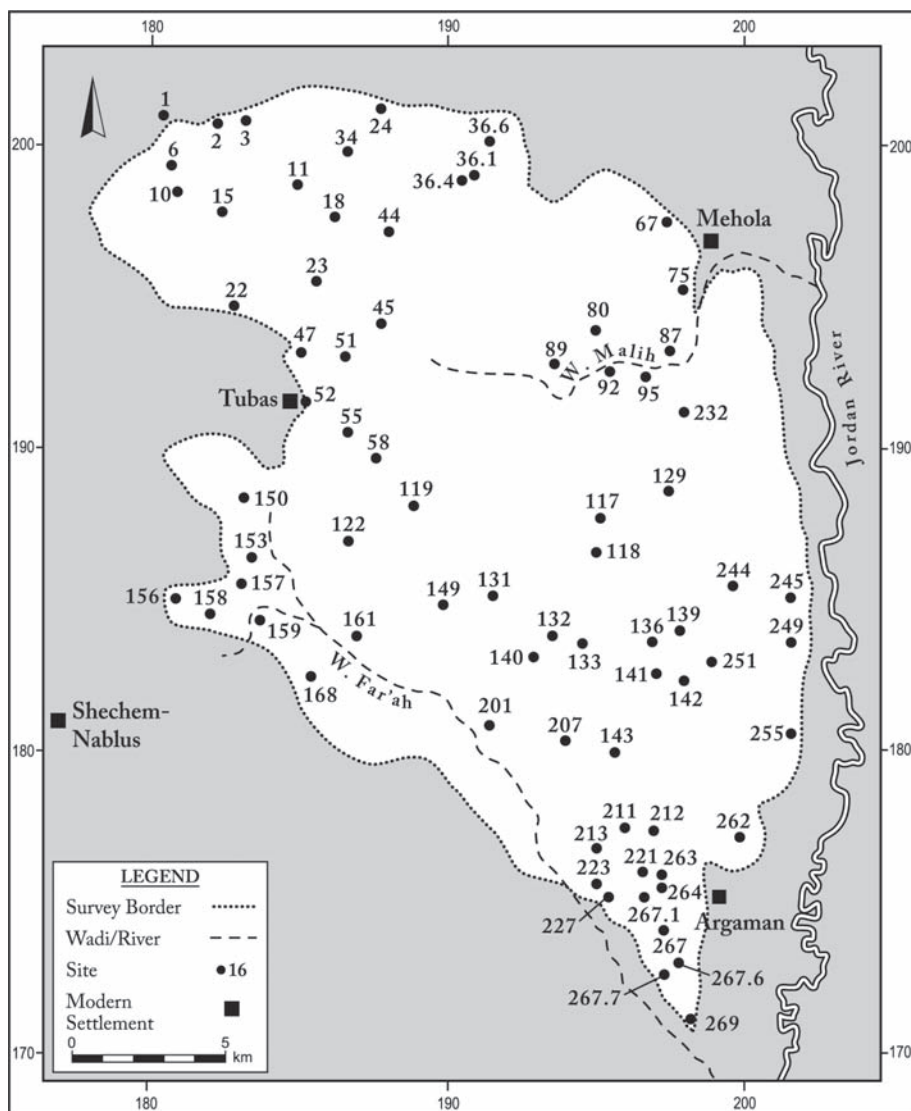
38. Map of the Early Moslem Period sites.

those of the preceding period.

Thirteen Early Moslem Period sites cease to exist, and 33 are newly founded. This addition is hard to explain, and one has to differentiate between the Crusader and Mameluk sites, an almost impossible task. This differentiation

should be based upon architecture and historical sources. Pottery plays a less important role. The following points are to be discussed:

A. During the Crusader Period two fortresses are built – Burj el-Malih and Burj el-Far'ah. Their style and period coincide with the



39. Map of the Middle Ages sites.

Crusaders, but no clear evidence exists as to their builders. Ellenblum (1991, 298-301) argued that Burj el-Malih was a senioric Crusader center, but the background for this claim is not clear. He found several Christian sites in central Samaria, including Zebabdeh and Rabbah. This argumentation is based upon Conder and Kitchener, who themselves hesitated, and finally based their definition upon the stone masonry.

To the Crusader site list one can add Bethphorum (Beth Farr [B] – no. 168), Thopas (Tubas) and possibly Taiyasir. The population consisted of Christians and Moslems, with slight Crusader (European) influences.

B. during the Mameluk Period several sites are founded. In eastern Buqe'ah there is a group of farms (Sunah [no. 139], Hadidiyeh [no. 136], Butmeh [no. 141], *etc.*), with newly cultivated lands. A parallel phenomenon, *i.e.* the foundation of farms, is also found north of Wadi Malih and in Wadi Far'ah, but above all new encampments with Mameluk material are found in East Buqe'ah, Mutaqallabat and Ras Kharrubeh. This is probably due to the rise of Bedouin power.

In the Shechem Syncline the number of sites rises moderately (Zertal 2004, 66-67). In Issachar, Zori found ten (!) "Crusader" sites. In Ephraim, Finkelstein (1988-1989, 163-164) reports about 153

sites from the Middle Ages, a figure parallel to ours.

17. Ottoman Period (= Ott, from the Ottoman conquest to the British Conquest)

This period sees a sharp settlement crisis, with only 26 sites clearly defined as Ottoman Period. Nine of these are villages, six are encampments and one is a cave. This find raises the issue of the accuracy of our pottery definition. It is simply hard to conceive of such a population vacuum. In the 1596 CE Ottoman census (Hutteroth and Abdel-Fatah 1977), only today's villages appear, with Bedouin tribes. This is also the situation during the British Survey (SWP, the 1870's) and in the map of Grossman (1986, fig. 5 in p. 340). Grossman, who literally explored the Ottoman period, presented a map particularly vacant of settlements.

Not only were no new sites founded, but many of the preceding farms ceased to exist. This situation may have evolved with the deterioration of the administration and the security situation, so that the "line of settlement" withdrew to the large villages of Tammun – Tubas – Zebabdeh. A somewhat similar picture was registered in other parts of the country in the 19th-20th centuries CE. This deterioration is expressed through the following:

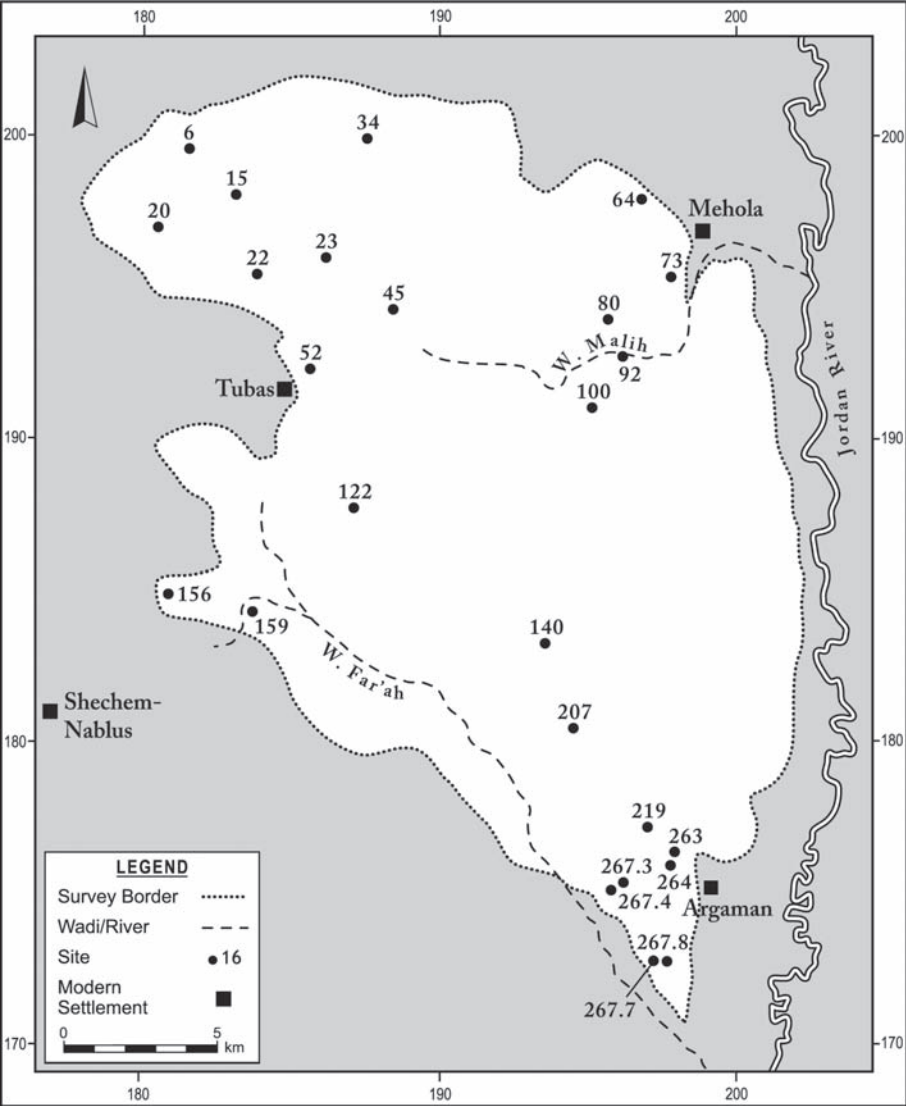
A. the population is sparse, con-

taining almost only Bedouins;

B. only few permanent villages or farms are known;

C. There is a large variety of Bedouins: true ones (*arab* in Arabic) with grazing rights but no lands; vassals (*harath*), who cultivate own-

ers' lands and pay with a portion of the crops; those coming from other regions (Judaea, Hebron), having grazing rights or others, and professional shepherds who handle the herds of the owners from the villages.



40. Map of the Ottoman Period sites.

CHAPTER THREE

THE GEOGRAPHICAL HISTORICAL IDENTIFICATIONS

In the identifications, use has been made of the new archaeological material found during the survey. Previous proposals have also been either supported or disproved.

East Manasseh has relatively few multi period sites, tells, geographical historical texts and identification options. Effort was made to use the available sources. The identifications are based, as usual, on the similarity and preservation of names, on the archaeological finds and on the geographical historical contexts. Next to each site is a short discussion, bibliography and, if relevant, our new proposal for identification.

The identifications from the Onomasticon of Eusebius are based on the new edition by Freeman-Grenville, Chapman and Taylor 2003.

Site no. 1:

Khirbet 'Anahum

Lemaire (1977, 63) has suggested identifying this site as No'ah of the Daughters of Zelophohad (Joshua 17:3; Samaria Ostraca, no. 50, 52, 64). This identification, supported by Taylor and Taylor (1992), is based upon the preservation of the

name and the context. The presence of Iron Age I pottery does not add or detract, since the date of division into Manasseh's family allotments has not been thoroughly researched. This identification, however, "stretches" the borders of the "Land of Hephher" (I Kings 4:10), to which the Daughters of Zelophohad belong (and see discussion in Zertal 1984, 50-58). In the Zebabdeh Valley four Iron Age I sites adjacent to the large Late Bronze Age site (Sheikh Safiriyan, no. 2) were found, and it seems that the entire valley was called No'ah.

The site was also identified by Zussman and Demsky as *Ananin* (עננין) of the "Permitted Villages" of the territory of Sebasteh in the *Rehov* Mosaic Inscription. This identification is based on the similarity in name and the archaeological finds. *Ananin* is located between *Shapirin* (Kh. ash-Sheikh Safiriyan, no. 2) and *Bil'am 'Aliata* (בלעם עלייתה, Kh. Bel'ameh; see Zertal 2004, site no. 26). Thus, a logical sequence exists for the location of Kh. 'Anahum and the identification is reasonable.

Bibliography: Lemaire 1977, 63; Demsky 1979, 189; Zussman 1981, 166.

Site no. 2:

Khirbet esh-Sheikh Safiriyan

It is suggested that Canaanite *Bezeq*, mentioned in Judges 1:4-5 as the city of Adonibezeq, might have been at this site. His name, which means “Ruler of the city [*Bezeq*]” correlates with Adonizedeq of Jerusalem (Joshua 10:1-3) and Adoniyah (II Samuel 3:4). However, a Canaanite god named *Bezeq* is unknown (although the meaning of the name *Bezeq* – “flash, lightning, swift” is close to *Hadad*, the god of the storm, rain, thunder and lightning (Maier 1992). The identity proposed by Wright (1946) of Adonibezeq with Adonizedeq seems to be unfounded.

The *Bezeq* traditions echo the Canaanite Israelite conflicts during the early Iron Age, and the existence of Judah and Simeon inside Manasseh (Zertal 2000, 280-285).

The geographic proximity of Safiriyan to Kh. Ibziq (no. 44) and Kh. Salhab (no. 23, the candidate for the other *Bezeq*) supports the identification of the former with Canaanite *Bezeq*. The place name may have been transferred about 5 km (from Safiriyan to Salhab) and then again to Kh. Ibziq. Such transferal is reasonable, and may echo the Israelite Canaanite conflict within the boundaries of the eastern valleys.

The site was also identified by Zussman as *Shapirin* (שפירין), line

27 of the *Rehov* Inscription, of the “Permitted Villages”. The finds, location and context make this identification possible.

Bibliography: for Adonibezeq, Schlei 1992; Zertal 1992b; for Shapirin, Demsky 1979, 189; Zertal 1992a; Zussman 1981, 166.

Site no. 14:

el-Khirbeh (ez-Zard)

Two options have been considered for this site:

1. The village of *Kfar Zir* (כפר ציר), line 27 of the *Rehov* Inscription. Zussman has proposed identifying *Kfar Zir* as the nearby village Sir (no. 20). However, the Byzantine Period site there is small. el-Khirbeh (ez-Zard), in contrast, was a large town 24 dunams (6 acres) in area, and thus appears to be a better candidate, although the finds and location fit both of them.

2. In a discussion of *Kfar Casdia* (כפר כסדיה) from the *Rehov* Inscription, the argument was raised (Zertal 2004, 71) that the finds there are insufficient for identification. Thus we proposed identifying *Kfar Casdia* as el-Khirbeh (ez-Zard). If so, *Kfar Zir* would remain in nearby Sir.

Bibliography: Demsky 1979, 189; Zussman 1981, 167; Zertal 2004, 76, 349-350.

Site no. 20:

Sir

During the Middle Ages a fortress named *Casale Syrorum* stood here. The name and the finds support the identification of Sir with ספר ציר from the *Rehov* Inscription (line 27); see previous site.

Bibliography: Beyer 1940, 175; Demsky 1979, 189; Zussman 1981, 167.

Site no. 22:

‘Aqabah

The identification with *Iqbin* (אקבין) of the “Permitted Villages” is supported by the location, geographical historical context and findings; and see discussion of site no. 84, Kh. el-‘Aqabah.

Bibliography: Demsky 1979, 189; Zussman 1981, 166.

Site no. 23:

Khirbet Salhab

This site is identified with biblical *Bezeq* (I Samuel 11:8), instead of the identification at nearby Kh. Ibziq.

This *Bezeq* is mentioned with relation to King Saul’s campaign. He gathers the people and commands them in *Bezeq*. From there, overnight, he reaches *Yabesh Gilead* and rescues its people. Kh. Salhab is situated on the road to Beth Shean and the Jordan Valley, and thus fits as a place of tactical assembly. The

distances to the Jordan and *Yabesh Gilead* may fit a one night’s march.

For Canaanite *Bezeq* see site no. 2, Safiriyan.

Kh. Salhab has also been identified as *Palga deShalaf* (פלגא דשלף) of the *Rehov* Inscription. The identification is reasonable regarding location and finds, but the site from the Byzantine Period is extremely small.

Bibliography: For an extensive discussion on Biblical identification see Welten 1965; Zertal 1990, 91-92; 1992a, 717-718. contra: Zuhari 1991. For *Palga Deshalaf* see Zussman 1981, 167.

Site No. 34:

Rabbah

Conder and Kitchener proposed identifying this place as *Harabit* in the allotment of Issachar (Joshua 19:20), mentioned only once in the Bible near *Kishion*. In the Septuagint and the Vulgate, *Dovrat* appears instead of *Harabit*. *Dovrat* also appears in Joshua 21:28 and in I Chronicles 6:57 as a Levite city.

Dovrat/Harabit is usually identified south of Mt. Tabor. However, the identification at Rabbah, suggested by Pere F.-M. Abel, is supported by the proximity to Nebi Rubin in Kh. Abu Farhan (*Rabit* = Rubin). The presence of groups from Issachar in Manasseh is reasonable (see also Mazar 1992a, 119ff). Yet in both sites, Rabbah

and Kh. Abu Farhan, no Iron Age shards were found, and there is no archaeological basis for this identification. On the other hand, name preservation may indicate an Iron Age site in the vicinity; see also Ras es-Salmeh.

Bibliography: Armstrong 1889, 146; Alt 1928, 37; Abel 1967b, 425; Baker 1992, 604-605.

Site no. 41:

Ras es-Salmeh

This is a candidate for *Harabit* in Issachar (Joshua 19:20). The name has been presumably preserved in the nearby village of Rabbah, and the pottery suits the settlement period of Issachar families within Manasseh. The borders of Issachar in Joshua 19 may be interpreted either in the region of Issachar Heights north of Beth Shean (Albright 1926; Kallai 1967, 164-173; Aharoni 1979, 250-256) or, according to the extended school (Yeivin 1958, 948-951), who include the Jezreel Valley, the Gilboa Range and the northern part of Dothan Valley. The well-known verse (Joshua 17:11) "And Manasseh had in Issachar and in *Asher*..." may fit the latter. It is possible that Rabbah, about 10 km away from *Yibleam* (mentioned also in Joshua 17:11) was included in this region. A certain difficulty arises in that *Harabit* is a Levite city in Issachar, while Ras es-Salmeh is a small site at the top of a mountain.

Bibliography: See above (Rabbah), and Albright 1926; Kallai 1967, 164-173; Gal 1980, with detailed discussion pp. 95-96 (which does not give a clear opinion regarding *Harabit*).

Sites no. 42, 44:

Khirbet Izbizq-Lower and Khirbet Izbizq

The ancient name *Bezeq* (Judges 1:4; I Samuel 11:8) has been preserved in these two places, and the similarity of the name induced all of the 19th century scholars (Conder and Kitchener, Guérin and others) to identify the Biblical site here (see also Aharoni 1979, 57, 122, 214, 287, 433; Zaharoni 1991, who still proposes this identification, vs. Gophna and Porath 1972, 201, who suggest reconsidering the identification). However, according to the finds the site was founded during Iron Age II, and the name *Bezeq* was transferred to this place during a later period (apparently at the end of the Iron Age) from the original site at Kh. Salhab. Then, it was preserved from the Byzantine period onwards. The evidence of Eusebius' Onomasticon: "*Bezeq*. A city of Adonibezeq. Today there are two neighboring villages called *Bezeq* 17 milestones away from Neapolis on the way down to Scythopolis", shows that in the 4th century CE the place was called by this name or something close to it. It can be suggested with high prob-

ability that Eusebius' two villages are both sites no. 42 and no. 44. See also discussion of site no. 23, Kh. Salhab.

Bibliography: Eusebius Onomasticon, 36; Conder 1876, 69; 1881, 44; Mazar 1973; Welten 1965; Zertal 1992a.

Site no. 45:

Taiyasir

This site was identified by Eusebius as *Asher* of the Manassite territory. Its definition is "*Aser* [IV], (Joshua 17:7). City of the tribe of Manasseh. Now there is a village so called on the way down from Neapolis to Scythopolis, 15 milestones along the highway" (Eusebius Onomasticon, 23). The identification is based on the border description of Manasseh: "and the border of Manasseh was from *Asher* to *Michmethath*, that lieth before Shechem" (Joshua 17:7). Germer Durand and Sejourne found milestones there inscribed "14", which may fit the description of Eusebius. The existence of Asherite families in Manasseh at the beginning of the Iron Age I period is well accepted (*cf.* Kallai 1967, 128; Aharoni 1979, 242ff; Avi Yonah 1972, column 786, which supports the *Asher* Taiyasir identification), as well as the name preservation in the area. However, Iron Age pottery is needed to support the identification at Taiyasir. This village is small and has almost no finds from this period. From

that point of view, we propose to transfer the place of *Asher* to nearby Kh. Yarzah.

Bibliography: Eusebius Onomasticon, 23; Guérin 1969, I, 356-357; Sejourne 1895, 617; Edelman 1992; Zertal 1990, 93-94 with discussion.

Site no. 47:

Khirbet Fuqahah

This is a candidate for the identification of *Thebez* (Judges 9:51-57). The biblical account provides no precise location of the city, but according to the context it must be in the Shechem region. A strong tower is described there (*ibid*, 51) in which the people of the town fortified themselves against Abimelech.

Eusebius in his Onomasticon (Eusebius Onomasticon, 58) notes: "Today it is still a village called Thebes on the borders of Neapolis about 13 milestones on the way to Scythopolis". The name has been preserved in the large village of Tubas, in which no ancient tell has been discovered; possibly it was made indistinct due to modern construction. In Tubas Valley, within the borders of the village, two tells with Iron Age I pottery were discovered that may be candidates for *Thebez*. The size, location and fortification of Kh. Fuqahah make identification there possible. In the lower part of the place there is also

a good sized Byzantine Period site, which may fit Eusebius' description. Yet the data do not permit a definite decision between this site and Kh. 'Eynun. See also site no. 58.

Bibliography (for Thebez): Sejourne 1895, 617; Abel 1967II, 477; Guérin 1969, I, 356-359; Milik 1966.

Site no. 52:

Tubas

A candidate for *Thebez* of the Onomasticon, as mentioned by Eusebius (*cf.* above), and perhaps also *Thopas* of the Crusader Period. The general tradition of *Thebez* is known from the Byzantine period onwards, but Biblical *Thebez* was presumably either in site no. 47 or in no. 58, with the ancient name moving to Byzantine Period Tubas. In addition, the Samaritans ascribe the tomb of *Nebi Tubah*, located in the village, to *Asher* the son of Ya'akov.

Bibliography: See Kh. Fuqahah (site no. 47), Beyer 1940, 172 ff., 189, 202 ff. and Ben-Zvi 1976, 73-74.

Site no. 58:

Khirbet 'Eynun

The second candidate for Biblical *Thebez* (*cf.* above). The large, fortified tell is located within the boundary of contemporary Tubas, about 2.5 km southeast of the town center. A wall of big stones, a large

shard scatter and rich finds from Iron Age I-II were all found there. The site is situated on the Roman road from the Tubas Valley to the Buqeia'h, and through location, geographical historical context and archaeological finds it is a suitable candidate for *Thebez*.

Conder and Kitchener proposed that this site was *Aenon* from the New Testament (John 3:23), an unreasonable proposition in considering the archaeological finds and geographical context.

Bibliography: SWP II, 230; Guérin 1969, I, 356-359; see additional bibliography in site no. 46.

Site no. 68:

Qasr esh-Sheikh Ghazal

This site may be identified as *Mutatis in Medio*, a road station between Neapolis and Scythopolis, as proposed by Neef. However, Qasr esh-Sheikh Ghazal is located on a secondary branch of the road, while the primary one apparently passed through Kh. Ibziq.

Bibliography: Neef 1982.

Site no. 69:

Khirbet Jabaris

This site was identified as the second village of *Bezeq* of the Onomasticon (Eusebius Onomasticon, 58, and *cf.* above, no. 44), Yet Kh. Jabaris is too far east and has no geographical connection with Kh. Ibziq. The two settlements next to

each other, Upper and Lower Kh. Ibbiq (sites 42 and 44), suffice to comprehend the Eusebius definition.

Bibliography: see the literature on Kh. Ibbiq, site no. 44.

Site no. 78:

Khirbet Mhallal

A new identification as *Mahlah*, a daughter of Zelophohad from the Manassite families (Joshua 17:3), is proposed. Lemaire (1977, 63) proposed locating *Mahlah* in the region of Wadi Malih. Zertal (2004, 74) suggested that each “daughter” represented a territory and a city (e.g., *Tirzah*). The large site of Kh. Mhallal fits the conditions for *Mahlah* well regarding period, name and geographical historical context.

Bibliography: Lemaire 1977, 83; Zertal 2004, 74.

Sites 81-83:

The esh-Shaqq sites

There may be a connection to *Succoth* (I Kings 7:46), where a metallurgical project was carried out by King Solomon. The name has probably been preserved in neighboring Kh. es-Sakkut (volume IV, see Zertal 2005, site 32). The concentration of Iron Age sites in the esh-Shaqq Valley, together with the similarity of the name (Shaqq=*Succoth*) make the Shaqq Valley a possible candidate for *Succoth*.

Bibliography: Guérin 1969, I, 204;

Abel 1967II, 450, 470.

Site No. 84:

Khirbet el-‘Aqqabah

This is the second candidate for *Iqbin* from the *Rehov* Inscription, together with the village of ‘Aqaba (site 22). Here was a small village, about 6 dunams (1.5 acres) in area, and about 50% of the pottery is Byzantine. Both the preservation of the name and the location are suitable to *Iqbin*; see discussion and bibliography of site no. 22.

Site No. 96:

Tel el-Hilu

The usually accepted identification, was *Abel Meholah* (Judges 7:22; I Kings 4:12; 19:16), is rendered doubtful by the results of the survey. This is due to the small area of the tell and the paucity of cultivatable areas in its environs.

The identification of Tel Abu Sus as *Abel Meholah* (Zobel 1966; Zertal 2005, site 33) seems to be much more logical and plausible.

Bibliography: SWP II, 231; Albright 1925, 32; Alt 1928, 42; 1932, 39; Abel 1967, II, 234; Glueck 1943, 9; Zobel 1966; Gophna and Porath 1972, 201; Zori 1977, 38-39; Edelman 1992a.

Site No. 104:

Khirbet Yarzah (B)

This site is identified as *Asher* from the Byzantine Period, as noted by Eusebius in his *Onomasticon* (*cf.* above, site no. 45). Many scholars has identified it at Taiyasir, but that place is small (the ancient core is only 2-3 dunams or 0.5-0.75 acre), with only sparse structural, pottery and other remains. *Asher*, therefore, should be transferred to Kh. Yarzah (B), 4 km southeast of Tayasir. Kh. Yarzah is connected to the Nepaolis - Scythopolis Roman road. Thus, Eusebius' description can be interpreted as "by" the King's Road.

The name *Asher* also suggests that Tel Yarzah (A), close to the former, kept the Biblical name *Asher*; see discussion of site no. 106 below.

Bibliography: SWP II, 169; Abel 1967II, 254; Guérin 1969,I, 355-357; Zertal 1990, 93-94.

Site No. 106:

Khirbet Yarzah (A)

The main allotment of the tribe of *Asher* was in the Western Galilee (Edelman 1992a), but families from the tribe are known to have resided in Ephraim (Aharoni 1979, 250-259), and Manasseh (Joshua 17:7, 11). During the period of the Israelite settlement families from several tribes, including *Asher*, are mentioned in Manasseh (see also Noth 1953, 127; Kallai 1967, 128; Avi Yonah 1972, col. 786).

Bibliography: Abel 1967II, 254; Zertal 1990, 93-94 (and see literature of previous site); Edelman 1992b.

Site No. 131:

Khirbet 'Atuf

The identification proposed by Robinson (1870) and Guérin (1969, I-II), that Kh. 'Atuf may be *Tappuah* of the Ephraim-Manasseh boundary (Joshua 17:7-8), is unacceptable in light of the results of the survey and the geographical historical analysis. *Tappuah* is located on Wadi Qana (Joshua 17:8-9), the southwest boundary of Manasseh, which descended from the *Michmethath* directly to the Mediterranean Sea. The Buqeia'ah can not be located on that boundary. Conder and Kitchener rejected Robinson's identification, based on mistaken identifications from the Middle Ages (Tammun = Tampne = *Tapuah*; see also Burchard of Mount Zion 1971, 52).

Bibliography: Guérin 1969, I, 255-256; SWP II, 237; Abel 1967II, 475-476.

Site No. 151:

Tel el-Far'ah (North)

Albright was the first to propose identifying this tell as the city of *Tirzah*, a Canaanite city state and the third capital of the Kingdom of Israel (Joshua 12:24; I Kings 12:17; 15:21; 15:33; 16:6; 16:8-9; 16:17;

16:23; II Kings 15:14; 15:16; Song of Songs 6:4). The French excavations headed by Pere R. De Vaux supported this identification, which now seems highly likely. The last attempt of Sapir (1991) to transfer *Tirzah* to the Lower Galilee is totally rejected.

Bibliography: SWP II, 284; Albright 1931; Abel 1967II, 485; Sapir 1991.

Site No. 155:

Khirbet esh-Sheikh Smett (B)

Guérin informs that the name *ʿAsir* was preserved near the tomb of Sheikh Smett. This may be the Arabic form of *Asher* (both have an equivalent ‘a). The place is not far from Taiyasir Yarzah, the candidates for *Asher*. Yet the value of the name is limited due to the etymology of the Arabic ‘Asir (“fruit juice”).

Bibliography: Guérin 1969, I, 261.

Site No. 156:

Khirbet Farweh

This site is identified as *Bedan* (בדן, Mishnah Orlah 3:7; Kelim 17:5), renowned for its splendid pomegranates. The place is also known in the Samaritan traditions. According to the Samaritan manuscript *Astir Moshe* (1:23) Adam, the first man, lived here, and the Samaritan Book of Joshua mentions that Joshua gathered the people here before ascending to Mount Garizim.

Bibliography: Avi Yonah 1966, 124; Ben-Zvi 1976, 73.

Site No. 160:

el-‘Unuq

The large, elliptically-shaped site, enclosed by a low stone wall, contains Iron Age I pottery (and a few shards from Iron Age II). This was possibly the *gilgal* (Deuteronomy 11:30), that appears in the topographical description of the entrance into Canaan. According to the above, Ebal and Garizim are located “beyond the Jordan after the road where the sun goes down, in the land of the Canaanites who dwell in the plain over against Gilgal beside Elonei Moreh.”

Our interpretation posits that “the road where the sun goes down” is the Shechem – Jordan road B3, along Wadi Far‘ah; “the land of the Canaanites who dwell in the plain” refers to Wadi Far‘ah Valley (see also Numbers 13:29: “and the Canaanites dwell by the sea and by the coast of Jordan”). el-‘Unuq is located next to the road of Wadi Far‘ah facing the hilltop of Sheikh Billal, possibly *Elonei Moreh*. At Sheikh Billal, potshards of Iron Age I were found. In this Deuteronomistic tradition a possible memory of the site has been preserved. The tradition is difficult to date, but an Iron Age I basis is highly probable. Thus, an archaeological interpretation can be proposed for the biblical *gilgal*.

Bibliography: Sellin 1917; Zertal 1991, 42-44; 1998, 246-247.

Site No. 166:

Khirbet Beit Farr (A)

Porath (1968, no. 72) proposed identifying the site as *Tiphseh* (I Kings 5:4; II Kings 15:16). There are two *Tiphseh*: the first (I Kings 5:4), which is irrelevant here, marks the border of Solomon's kingdom (Hull 1992, no. 1). The second *Tiphseh* (II Kings 15:16) may relate to our area: "Then Menahem smote Tiphseh and all that were therein, and its borders from *Tirzah* because they opened not to him...". This reference denotes a border point opposite *Tirzah*. If, as appears in the Septuagint, this is a corruption of the name *Tappuah* - no site in Wadi Far'ah fits it. The mention of the name is puzzling and unclear, and the basis for the identification is associated only with *Tirzah* (see also the discussion of Hull 1992, 571).

Bibliography: Porath 1968, no. 72; Hull 1992.

Site No. 168:

Khirbet Beit Farr (B)

The later ruin of Beit Farr (B) is identified as *Bethphorum*, mentioned in the Crusader inscriptions from the 12th century CE. This identification is logical, based on preservation of the name and the findings.

Bibliography: Beyer 1940, 173 ff; Kappus 1966, 79-80; Porath 1968, no. 72.

Site No. 194:

Khirbet Basaliyeh

Guérin correctly showed that there was no basis for identifying the site as *Archelais* of Josephus (*Antiquities* 18:2:2)

Bibliography: Guérin 1969, I, 251-253.

Site No. 248:

'Iraq Abu Hashish (A)

The site is a Roman *castellum* (military camp) whose construction was never completed. It is situated about 24 km south of Beth Shean and 1 km west of the Beth Shean - Jericho road. In light of these data, the site may be identifiable as *Coabis*, a road station on the Peutinger map from the 2nd century CE. The road station is located 12 Roman miles south of Beth Shean. Since this site is not mentioned afterwards, it seems that it was in use for only a short period. However, an unfinished building on an official map as a road station is problematic.

Bibliography: for the Peutinger map, Miller 1916; for the site, Zertal 1992c, 8-15.

PART TWO

DESCRIPTION OF THE SITES

CHAPTER FOUR

ZEBABDEH VALLEY

LANDSCAPE UNIT 12



A valley in northern Samaria, etching by W. H. Bartlett
From: *Footsteps of Our Lord*, London 1841

Site 1: 17 – 20/90/1

Khirbet 'Anahum (SWP map: Kh. en-Nahm)

Israel grid: 1799 2009

UTM grid: 7180 5877

Elevation: 345 m a.s.l., 30 m a.s.a.

Name type: on map as historical site

Site type: medium-sized site

Area: 8 dunams (2 acres)

Topography: ridge edge, valley edge
and slope

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa and alluvium;

quality: 8

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: 3

Nearest water source: well (Bir el-Haffireh, no. 40), 5 km distant

Nearest road: Far'ah – Qabatiyeh
junction (B5), passes by site

Visibility: 4

Dec. 30, 1982, 82 shards

* * *

A ruin on the edge of a low ridge, overlooking Zebabdeh Valley from the north. It is near both a large quarry and the ancient pass from Zebabdeh Valley to Dothan Valley.

Foundations of buildings dating to the Middle Ages are in the western portion of the site. The ruin is cultivated and cleared of stones, with building stones concentrated in the terrace walls. Most



41. Kh. 'Anahum, looking northeast.

of the shards from the early periods (Bronze and Iron Ages) were collected in a plowed field south of the site.

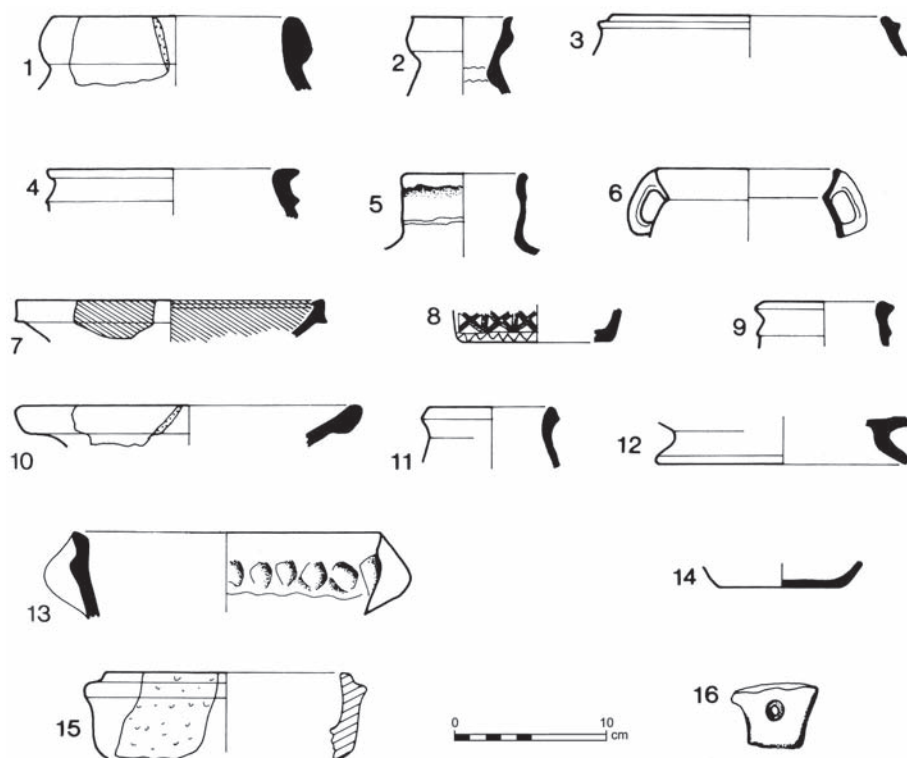
Pottery: MBA IIB – 5%; IrA IB – 10%; IrA II – 2%; IrA III – 3%; Per – 8%; Hel – 2%; ER – 5%; LR – 5%; Byz – 20%; EM – 10%; MA – 30%.

Coin find: Byzantine and Modern, and see appendix.

Identification: Identified as 'Ananin, a "permitted" town in the Sebastiyeh region. A possible identification with *No'ah* of the Manasseh families (Joshua 17:3-7), and see chapter on identifications.

Previous surveys: Gophna and Porath 1972, no. 36.

Bibliography: SWP II, 240; Demsky 1979, 189 (regarding identification).



42. Shards from Kh. 'Anahum: nos. 1, 3, 16 – IrA I; 4, 9, 14 – IrA II. 1. Pythos, gray; 2. Jug, lt br, Rom; 3. CP, dk br; 4. Jar, dk; 5. Jar, gray, LR; 6. CP, br, ER; 7. Bowl, pk, red slip, LR; 8. Jug, bl, MA; 9. Jar, br/bl; 10. Bowl, yel, Per; 11. Jar, lt, Hel; 12. Bowl, yel, Per; 13. Bowl, br, EM-MA; 14. Bowl, br; 15. Bowl, basalt; 16. Handle with indented dec, br.

Site 2: 18 – 20/10/1

Khirbet esh-Sheikh Safiriyan (PEF map: Kh. Safiriyeh)

Israel grid: 1815 2007

UTM grid: 7195 5874

Elevation: 360 m a.s.l., 7 m a.s.a.

Name type: historical site on map

Site type: large ruin and sheikh's tomb

Area: 20 dunams (5 acres)

Topography: valley edge and slope

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: alluvium; quality: 9

Cultivation: uncultivated and field crops

Cisterns: 30

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain Ginai, no. 35), 6 km distant

Nearest road: Far'ah – Qabatiyeh junction (B5), 3 km distant

Visibility: 3

Nov. 5; 1980, 142 shards

* * *

A large ruin on the low, northern edge of Zebabdeh Valley, west of Tilfit Range. It is located between Khallet esh-Sheikh (west) and Wadi

Abu Mar'ai (east). The ruin extends over both sides of Khallet esh-Sheikh Ravine.

Over almost 10 dunams (2.5



43. The large site of Sheikh Safiriyan on the edge of Zebabdeh Valley, viewed southward. At the center the small tomb of Sheikh Safiriyan is visible, surrounded by remains of structures from the later village (Roman to Medieval periods). Bottom right, towards the valley, stretched the ancient site (Bronze and Iron Ages). Behind the site the Khallet esh-Sheikh Ravine can be seen. Winter 1993.

acres) in the higher part of the ruin are many crowded structures, dated by pottery from the Late Roman Period onwards; the constructions seems to be medieval. Most of the buildings here are houses and courtyards built of large, hewn stones, with installations and cisterns. In the center of this section stands the ruined tomb of Sheikh Safiriyan. About 150 m east of the tomb are two stone *sarcophagi*, one decorated. The earlier settlement (Middle Bronze Age to Roman period) is located in cultivated fields on the lower part of the site, with a large quantity of shards there.

Pottery: MBA IIB – 20%; LBA I – 5%; LBA II – 5%; LBA III – 10%;

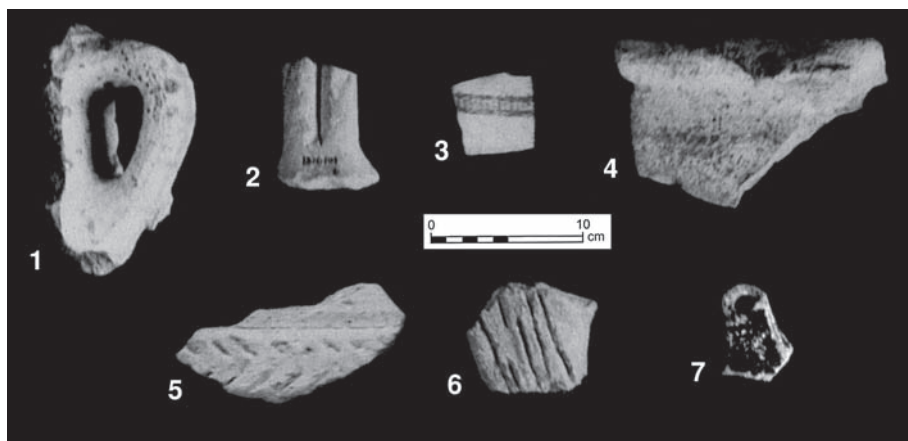
IrA IA-B – 10%; IrA II – 5%; IrA III – 5%; Per – 10%; Hel – 5%; ER – 5%; LR – 5%; Byz – 5%; EM – 5%; MA – 5%.

Special finds: Fragments of bowl with wedge decoration and one coin, and see appendix.

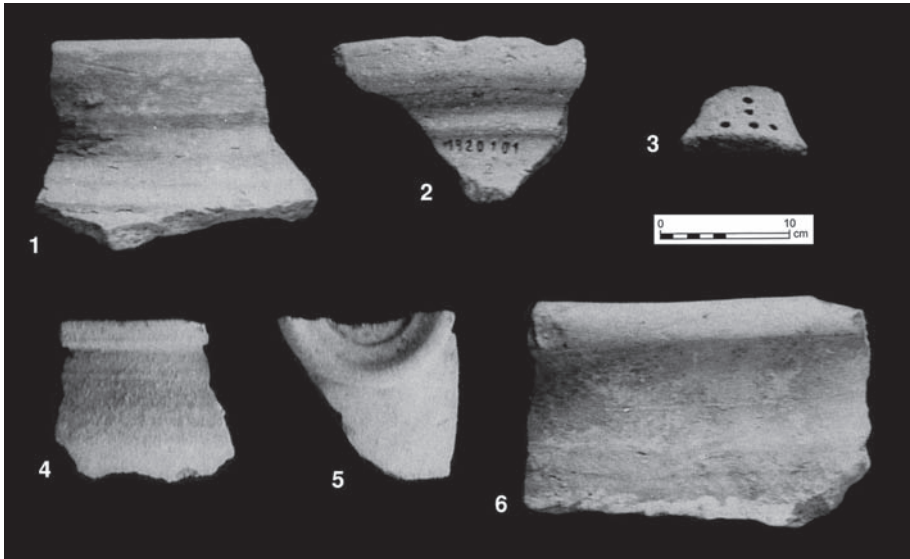
Identification: Probably *Bezeq* (Judges 1: 4-7), a Canaanite town. It is also identified as *Shapirin* of the *Rehov* inscription (line 27), and see chapter on identifications.

Previous surveys: Gophna and Porath 1972, no.37.

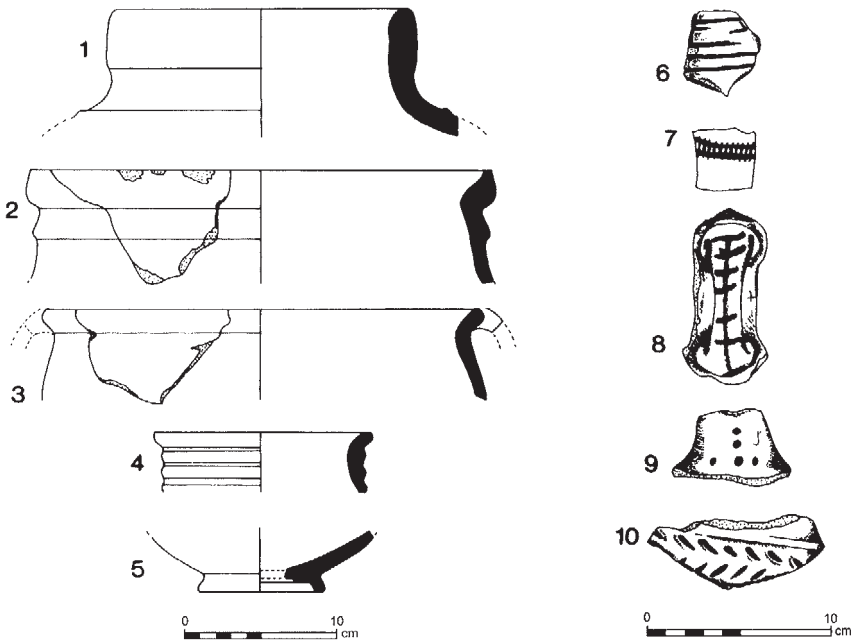
Bibliography: SWP II, 240; Zussman 1981, 166; Zertal 2000, 282-285 (regarding identification).



44. Shards from Kh. esh-Sheikh Safiriyan: 1-2. Handles, IrA and MBA II; 3. 'Milk bowl', Cypriot, LBA; 4. Crater, MBA II; 5-6. Plastic dec, MBA; 7. Oil lamp, Hel.



45. Shards from Kh. esh-Sheikh Safiriyan: 1, 6. Collared rim pythoi, IrA I; 2. Jar, MBA II; 3. Indented dec, IrA I; 4. Jar, MBA; 5. Bowl base, LBA.



46. Pottery from Kh. esh-Sheikh Safiriyan: 1. Pythos, dk, IrA I; 2. Crater, bl/gray, LBA-IrA I; 3. Crater, yel, MBA II; 4. Jar, yel, MBA II; 5. Bowl, lt, LBA; 6. Incised dec on handle, MA; 7 'Milk bowl' Cypriot, lt, LBA; 8. Dec handle, red on yel, LBA; 9. Handle with indented dec, IrA I; 10. "Fishbone" dec on jar, yel, MBA II.

Site 3: 18 – 20/20/1

Tilfit

Israel grid: 1823 2008

UTM grid: 7180 5877

Elevation: 390 m a.s.l., 40 m a.s.a.

Name type: on map, but not as historical site

Site type: large ruin and Arab village

Area: 15 dunams (3.75 acres)

Topography: ridge edge, valley edge and hilltop

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa and alluvium; quality: 8

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 35

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain Ginai, no. 35), 6 km distant

Nearest road: Far'ah – Qabatiyeh junction (B5), 3 km distant

Visibility: 6

Dec. 18, 1980; 1984-1986; 31 shards

* * *

A small Arab village on a tell located upon the high, eastern edges of Zebabdeh Valley. It is isolated from the north and the west by slopes descending to Wadi Khalil. To its east

are a ridge and a saddle, through which the road to Jalkamus passes. From the village is a fine view of Zebabdeh Valley.

In the upper part of the village



47. The tell and the small village of Tilfit from a bird's eye view, looking east. The tell's slopes descend to Wadi Khalil (left); remnants of the city wall (?) can be seen on the high part of the slope. Behind the village is the road to Jalkamus. Winter 1993.

are ancient buildings and wall foundations, apparently dating to the Byzantine and Early Moslem Periods. On the northern and western slopes are three earthen steps 3-4 m high each, the middle one of which seems to be a city wall, possibly dating to the Byzantine or Early Moslem Period. Ancient building stones are interwoven in the house- and terrace walls.

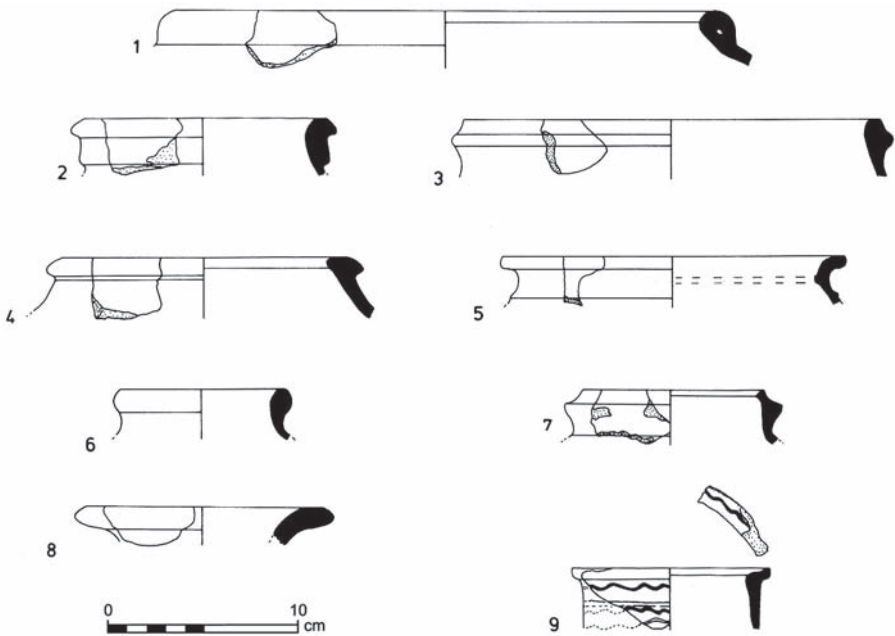
The village is not mentioned in

the 1596 Ottoman census.

Pottery: MBA IIB – 2%; IrA II – 5%; Per – 3%; ER – 10%; LR – 10%; Byz – 30%; EM – 10%; MA – 30%.

Previous surveys: Gophna and Porath 1972, no. 38, where three periods are attributed to the site (Byzantine, Medieval and Ottoman).

Bibliography: SWP II, 240 (the site appears as Kh. Tilfit).



48. Pottery from Tilfit: 1-2. Folded CP and jar, br and lt, MBA II; 3-4. Craters, dk br, IrA II; 5. Bowl, lt, ER; 6. Jar, gray, Per; 7. Jar, br, Byz; 8. Jar, lt br, LR; 9. Jar, gray, EM.

Site 4: 18 – 20/30/1

el-Habayel (A)

Israel grid: 1834 2001

UTM grid: 7215 5867

Elevation: 365 m a.s.l., 20 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: medium sized ruin

Area: 6 dunams (1.5 acres)

Topography: valley edge and slope

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: alluvium; quality: 8

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain Ginai, no. 35), 7 km distant

Nearest road: Far'ah – Qabatiyeh junction (B5), 2 km distant

Visibility: 5

Nov. 5, 1980; 72 shards and 69 flint items

* * *

A site on the high, eastern edges of Zebabdeh Valley, about 1 km north of the Zebabdeh – Rabbah road. A dirt road along the valley edge passes nearby, and a path from Tilfit to Rabbah crosses the site, from which there is a fine view of Zebabdeh Valley.

The site extends over a slope, with well preserved structures on its upper part. These are built of field stones, rectangular in shape and measuring 8x5 m in size. At the lower slope is an artificial ramp in a cultivated field, presumably indicating a wall. Most of the shards



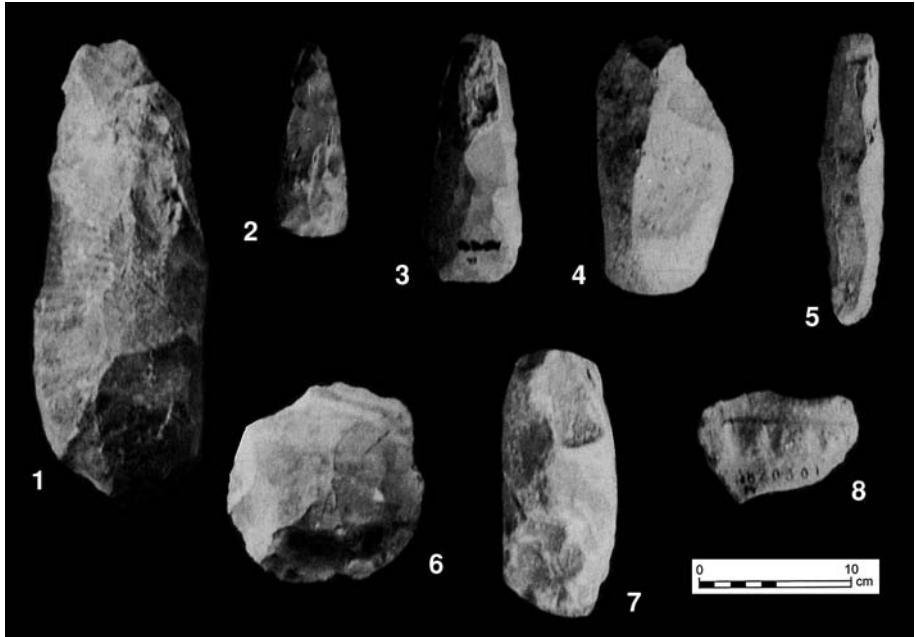
49. The village of Tilfit with the Chalcolithic Period sites of el-Habayel to its right.

and flint finds were collected in this field next to the ramp. A spring, that has since dried up, was possibly existent in Wadi Khudrah.

Pottery: Chal – 100%.

Flint find: Ghassulian Chalcolithic and Wadi Rabbah Periods; see appendix.

Previous surveys: none.



50. Flint adzes and stone tools from the Chalcolithic Period site of el-Habayel (A).



Site 5: 18 – 20/30/3

el-Habayel (B)

Israel grid: 1835 2002

UTM grid: 7214 5870

Elevation: 375 m a.s.l., 5 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: small site and shard scatter

Area: 0.5 dunam (0.125 acre)

Topography: slope and ravine

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa; quality: 7

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain Ginai, no. 35), 7 km distant

Nearest road: Far'ah – Qabatiyeh junction (B5), 2 km distant

Visibility: 2

Nov. 5, 1980; 77 shards and flint items

A site on a slope which descends moderately westwards into Zebabdeh Valley, some 0.4 km northeast of el-Habayel (A).

The structural remains here consists of a semi-circular wall delineating a small area whose center is sunken. In addition, there are three

caves, with openings blocked by stones, in the western part of the site. The place is located within rich agricultural land.

Pottery and flint find: Chal – 100%.

Previous surveys: none.



Site 6: 18 – 19/09/1

ez-Zebabdeh (PEF map: Zebabdeh)

Israel grid: 1807 1992

UTM grid: 7187 5858

Elevation: 330 m a.s.l., 10 m a.s.a.

Name type: on map, but not as historical site

Site type: large ruin and Arab village

Area: 30 dunams (7.5 acres)

Topography: valley edge and hilltop

Rock type: alluvium cover

Soil type: alluvium; quality: 8

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 35

Nearest water source: spring (‘Ain Ginai, no. 35), 6 km distant

Nearest road: Far‘ah – Qabatiyeh junction (B5), passes by site

Visibility: 5

Nov. 2, 1985, 48 shards

A large village on the northwestern part and margins of Zebabdeh Valley, on a natural hill protruding slightly from the valley plain. Nearby is a crossroads: the eastern branch of the main road from Shechem to Dothan, via Tubas, crosses the village, while the roads to Sanur Valley and the villages of Tilfit and Jalkamus branch off from the main road.

The village is located on a large tell, with many potsherds at its edges. In the center of the village several structures from the Middle Ages and the Ottoman Periods are

located, among them some churches. Many ancient building stones are in secondary use throughout the village.

Pottery: MBA IIB – 10%; IrA IB – 10%; IrA II – 10%; ER – 10%; LR – 10%; Byz – 10%; EM – 10%; MA – 20%; Ott – 10%.

Until recent past, many of the inhabitants were Christians. The village does not appear in the Ottoman census of 1596. According to Grossman the place was settled only in the 18th century, by shepherds from Ramallah.

Previous surveys: Gophna and Porath 1972, no. 44.

Bibliography: SWP II, 229; Beyer 1940, 203; Grossman 1986, 350.



51. The large village of ez-Zebabdeh from a bird's eye view, looking north. Churches, which served the Christian population of the village until recently, are visible on the ancient tell, in the center of the village. The road crossing the village comes from Tubas (at right) and leads to Dothan Valley (left). Winter 1994.

Site 7: 18 – 19/49/1

er-Rahweh

Israel grid: 1848 1993

UTM grid: 7227 5860

Elevation: 470 m a.s.l., 70 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: enclosure

Area: 7 dunams (1.75 acres)

Topography: ridge edge and hilltop

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa and alluvium;

quality: 4

Cultivation: orchards

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain

Ginai, no. 35), 9 km distant

Nearest road: Far'ah – Qabatiyeh

junction (B5), 2 km distant

Visibility: 6

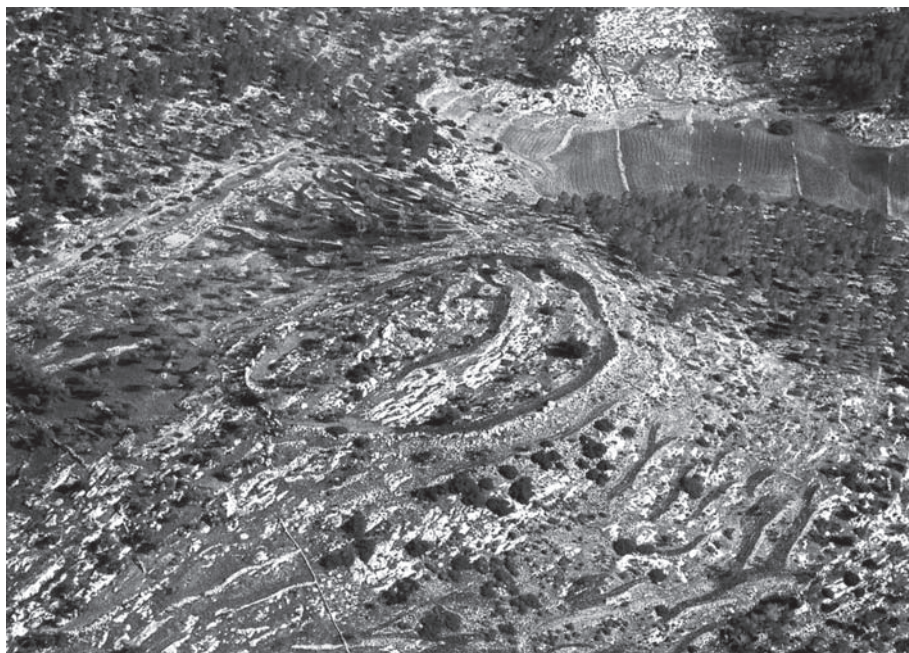
Oct. 30, 1980, 17 shards

* * *

An enclosure on a low summit, located on a range sloping to the Zebabdeh Valley from Ras es-Salmeh. The Zebabdeh – Rabbah road passes north of the site, which offers a good view to the valley and

the plains.

The summit is surrounded by an enclosure almost 80 m in diameter, built of megalithic stones. These are mostly in upright position, 1-



52. The MBA I enclosure in er-Rahweh. The elliptic-shaped enclosure, surrounded by a wall of large boulders, is on a low summit descending into the valley. Behind it is the Khallet Taleb Ravine. 1993.

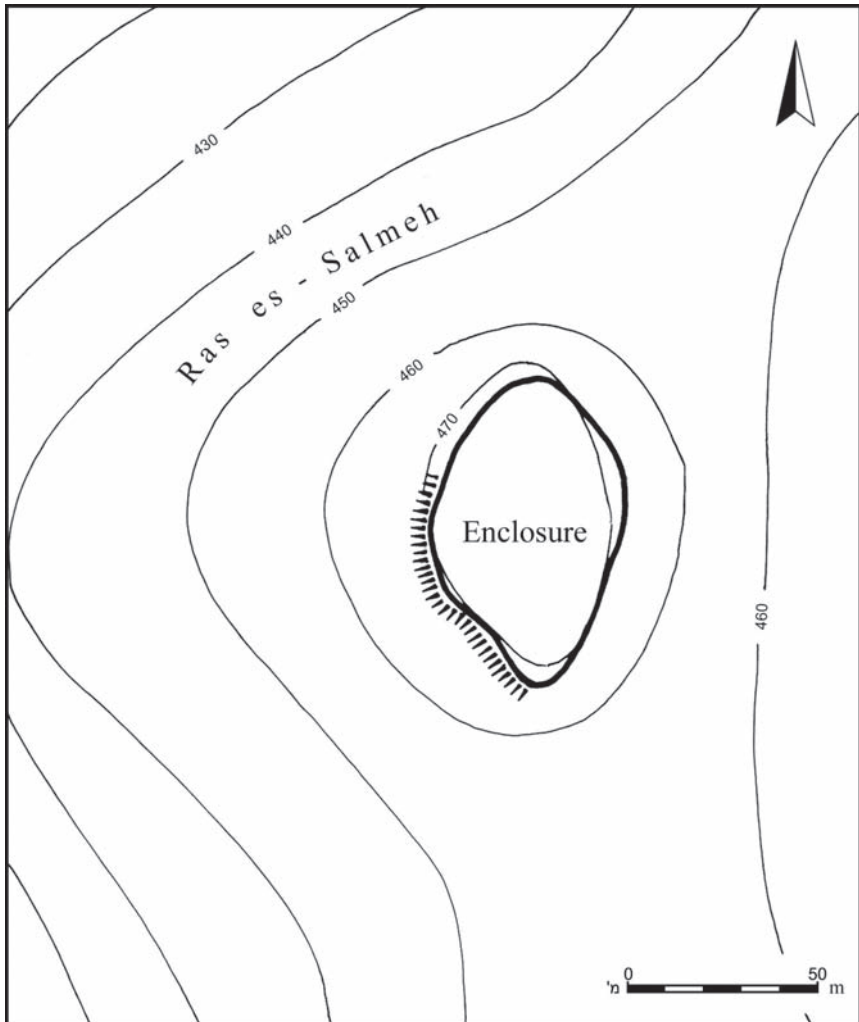
2 m high. The enclosure is oval yet slightly irregular in shape, with a sharpened point in the south. In three spots and between upright stones assumed entrances were detected. In the eastern section the wall was covered by cleared stones, and near the wall are many rock surfaces with cup marks. The num-

ber of shards is minimal.

During the Middle Bronze Age I the site was used probably as a cultic site for the nearby valley. There is a resemblance to el-'Ajjam (site no. 146), dated to the same period.

Pottery: MBA I – 98%; Byz – 2%.

Previous surveys: none.



53. Plan of er-Rahweh enclosure. Three similar sites, apparently cultic, are close to clusters of settlements in this volume.

Site 8: 17 – 19/98/1

Khallet 'Abhar

Israel grid: 1793 1987

UTM grid: 7173 5854

Elevation: 422 m a.s.l., l.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: structure and shard scatter

Area: 0.3 dunam (0.08 acre)

Topography: plateau and ridge

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 8

Cultivation: orchards

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain

Ginai, no. 35), 6 km distant

Nearest road: Far'ah – Qabatiyeh

junction (B5), 3 km distant

Visibility: 6

July 11, 1979, 19 shards

* * *

A structure on the upper, western slope of Jebel 'Abhar, a hilly mass with olive trees between the villages of Zebabdeh, Meseliyeh and Sir. West of it is Jebel Kheir and to the north passes the Zebabdeh - Meseliyeh asphalt road.

There is a structure of large field

stones, about 5x30 m in size. The plan is not clear due to the stones covering it. Only few shards were collected.

Pottery and flint find: Chal – 100%.

Previous surveys: none.



Site 9: 18 - 19/08/1

Khallet Feyaz

Israel grid: 1800 1989

UTM grid: 7179 5855

Elevation: 375 m a.s.l., 15 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: concentration of installations

Area: 2.8 dunams (0.7 acre)

Topography: slope and plateau

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa and Mediterra-

nean brown forest soil; quality: 5

Cultivation: orchards

Cisterns: 18

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain

Jerbah, no. 49), 6 km distant

Nearest road: Far'ah – Qabatiyeh

junction (B5), 2 km distant

Visibility: 5

July 11, 1979, 38 shards

* * *

A site with installations on a moderate slope, descending eastwards

from Feyaz Ridge to the village of Zebabdeh, about 0.5 km west of

that village. Nearby is a built path from Zebabdeh to Sir.

Large rock surfaces, used for quarrying building stones during the Late Roman and Byzantine Periods, are located on the site. Similar quarries are found in the entire area, which excels in high quality stone for building. Nearby there are many large hewn cisterns, with

a hewn channel leading to them. This channels is 15 m long and 20 cm wide. The character of the place, a settlement or a concentration of installations, is difficult to determine.

Pottery: ER – 20%; LR – 20%; Byz – 60%.

Previous surveys: none.



Site 10: 18 - 19/08/2

Khallet ej-Ja'ar

Israel grid: 1804 1987

UTM grid: 7182 5851

Elevation: 420 m a.s.l., l.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: farm

Area: 2 dunams (0.5 acre)

Topography: slope and plateau

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa and Mediterra-

nean brown forest soil; quality: 8

Cultivation: orchards

Cisterns: 4

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain Jerbah, no. 49), 6 km distant

Nearest road: Far'ah – Qabatiyeh junction (B5), 2 km distant

Visibility: 5

July 11, 1979, 33 shards

* * *

A small site at the top of the eastern slope of the Khallet Ja'ar mass, 0.5 km south of the Zebabdeh village.

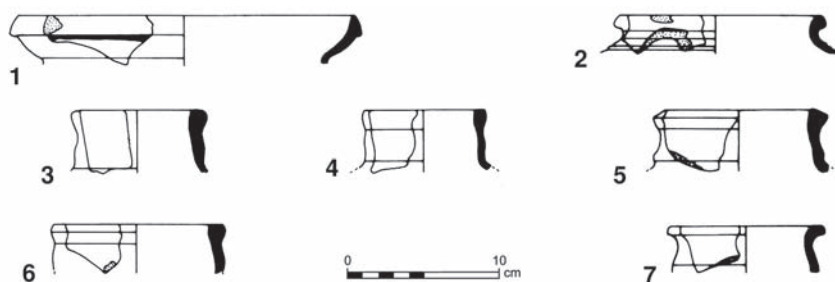
A structure of large stones, two courses high and 6 m long (façade), was found at the site. To its western side a courtyard, 15x30 m in size, is attached with hewn cisterns and a hewn installation nearby. The latter is rectangular in shape, 1x1.5 m in

size and 0.4 m in depth.

The site was originally an Iron Age farm, while the present structure was apparently built in the Roman–Byzantine period.

Pottery: IrA II – 40%; ER – 10%; LR – 10%; Byz – 20%; EM – 10%; MA – 10%.

Previous surveys: none.



54. Shards from Khamlet ej-Ja'ar: 1. Bowl, red, lt, LR; 2. Jar, br, IrA II; 3-4, 6-7. Jars, lt br, ER; 5. Jar, bl/orange, IrA II.



Site 11: 18 - 19/48/1

Khamlet Taleb

Israel grid: 1848 1986

UTM grid: 7226 5857

Elevation: 440 m a.s.l., l.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: large ruin

Area: 60 dunams (15 acres)

Topography: valley edge, slope and valley

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: alluvium; quality: 8

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain Ginai, no. 35), 8 km distant

Nearest road: Far'ah – Qabatiyyeh junction (B5), 2 km distant

Visibility: 5

Oct. 15, 1980, 86 shards

A large, scattered site on the low, eastern edges of Zebabdeh Valley. North of it the Zebabdeh – Rabbah road enters the hilly area east of the valley.

The site extends over a strip some 1 km long and 60 m wide, which begins near the Zebabdeh – Rabbah road in the north. Several groups of square building foundations, each 6x8 m in size, were located along the strip. The constructions are built of walls of very large, aligned

stones. Many structures are marked by cairns of cleared stones. Dismantled structures seem to have existed in the past where no remains are found today. A large quantity of potsherds is scattered around the buildings and in the surrounding fields.

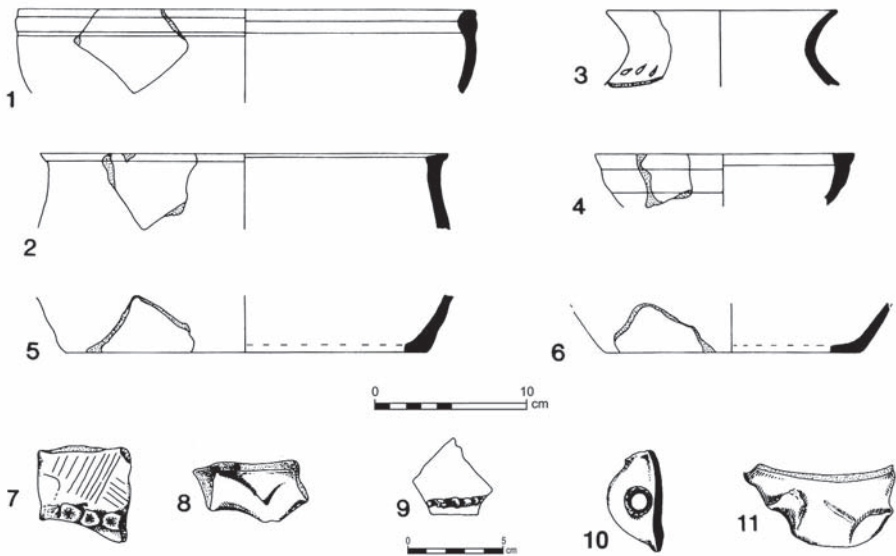
The scattered settlement is one of the largest in this area.

Pottery: MBA I – 100%.

Previous surveys: none.



55. Khallet Taleb at the edge of Zebabdeh Valley, looking eastward. To the right the summit of Ras es-Salmeh is seen; beyond the low ridge at left is the er-Rahweh enclosure. Summer 1982.



56. Pottery from the MBA I site of Khallet Taleb, all from this period: 1-2. Big bowls, yel; 3. Jar, gray, incised dec; 4. Bowl, br; 5-6. Flat bases of jars, yel; 7. Incised dec on jar; 8-11. Ledge handles, indentation, rope dec, jars and HM jars, gray and yel.

Site 12: 17- 19/87/1

Khirbet Mgharet el-Kih

Israel grid: 1782 1978

UTM grid: 7163 5844

Elevation: 430 m a.s.l., l.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: medium-sized ruin

Area: 5 dunams (1.25 acres)

Topography: valley and plateau

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa; quality: 8

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: 2

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain Jerbah, no. 49), 3.5 km distant

Nearest road: Jab'ah – Qabatiyeh junction (C7), 2 km distant

Visibility: 3

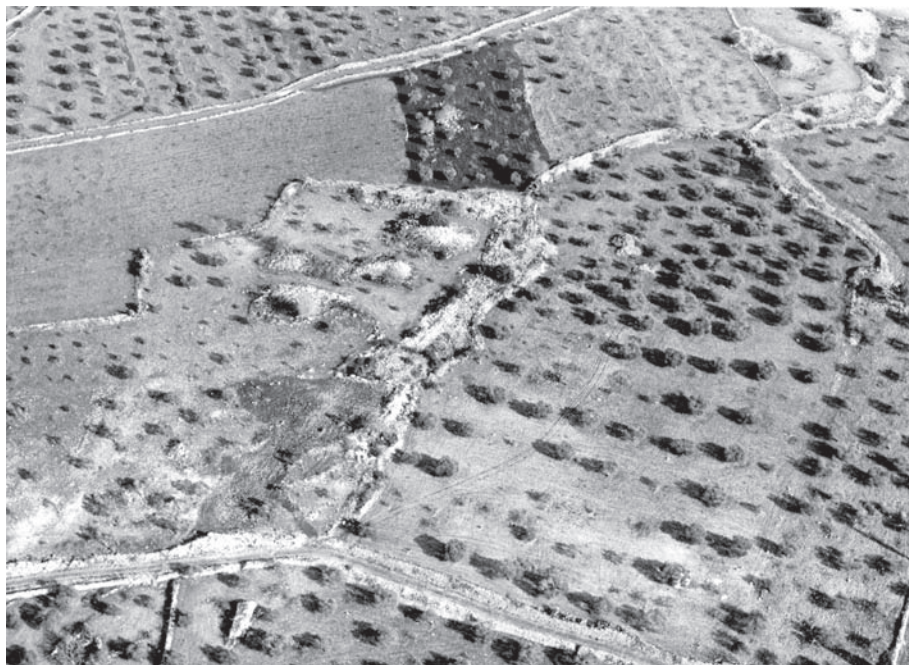
Ap. 13, 1979; Nov. 18, 1981,
59 shards

* * *

A ruin on a plateau, above the eastern margins of Sanur Valley and between the villages of Meseliyeh in the northwest and Sir in the southeast. Several paths and roads pass

near the ruin, connecting the two villages. Others descend into Sanur Valley.

The site, slightly elevated above



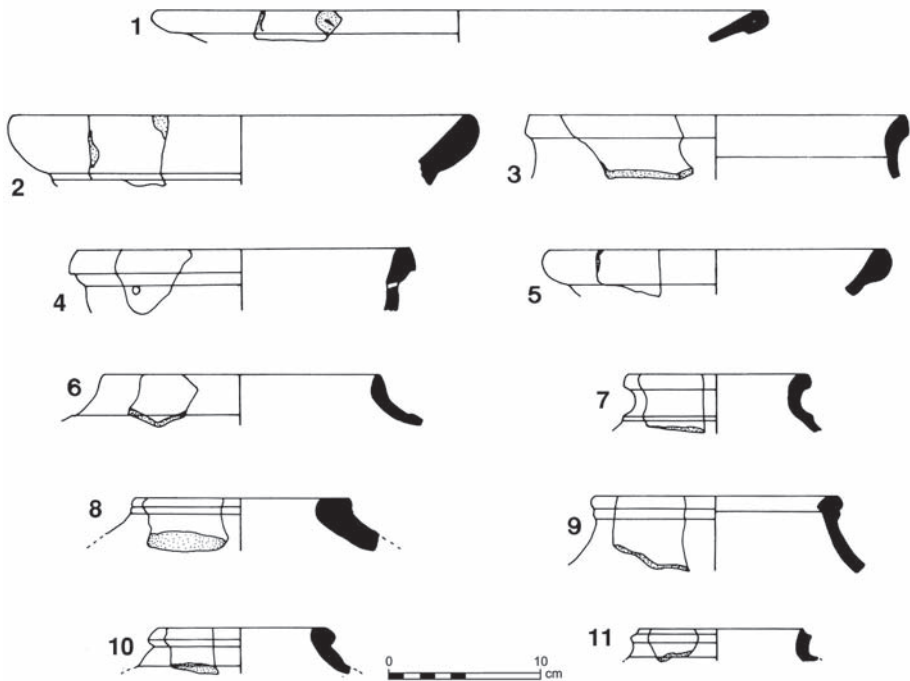
57. The Iron Age and Persian Period fortified site of Kh. Mgharet el-Kih in a bird's eye view, looking east. Remnants of the wall and the courtyard are seen left of center. Inside the structures can be seen cairns. The road in the upper side leads from Sir (to the right) to Meseliyeh (to the left). 1993.

the plain, is enclosed by a wall preserved in the south and east. It includes rooms built of field stones and measuring 6x5 m. The surrounding wall apparently encompassed the entire site in the past, but clearing of stones has damaged its western and northern sides. A tower of large field stones is located at the southeastern corner, while another one – square in shape and

built upon a semicircular base – has a square projection on the eastern side. The area inside the wall is cultivated, with two solitary structures (5x5 m each). All the buildings are preserved to 2-3 m of height. West of the site there are cisterns.

Pottery: IrA II – 10%; IrA III – 15%; Per – 75%.

Previous surveys: none.



58. Pottery from Kh. Mgharet el-Kih, all Per except 3 and 7: 1-2. Bowls, gray; 3, Crater, brown, IrA II; 4-6. Bowls, yel and gray; 7-11. Jars, br and yel (no. 7 – IrA II).

Site 13: 17 – 19/97/1

Abu el-‘Ubed

Israel grid: 1792 1977

UTM grid: 7191 5842

Elevation: 440 m a.s.l., 2 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: shard scatter and cave

Area: 0.5 dunam (0.125 acre)

Topography: valley edge and slope

Rock type: ‘Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa; quality: 8

Cultivation: orchards

Cisterns: 1

Nearest water source: spring (‘Ain Jerbah, no. 49), 6 km distant

Nearest road: Jab‘ah – Qabatiyeh junction (C5), 4 km distant

Visibility: 2

May 27, 1979, 18 shards

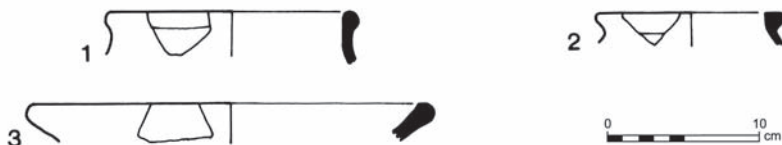
* * *

A tiny site on the northeastern part of Sahl Fuheis, a plateau north of Sanur Valley. The site is a shard scatter covering two steps on the south of Jebel Abu el-‘Ubed, near

Sahl Fuheis. East of the place there is a large cave.

Pottery: Per – 100%.

Previous surveys: None.



59. Shards from Abu el-‘Ubed, all Per: 1-2. Jars, gray; 3. Bowl, yel.



Site 14: 18 – 19/07/1

el-Khirbeh (ez-Zard)

Israel grid: 1801 1971

UTM grid: 7181 5837

Elevation: 440 m a.s.l., 30 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: large ruin

Area: 24 dunams (6 acres)

Topography: ridge edge and plateau

Rock type: ‘Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa, alluvium and

Mediterranean brown forest soil;

quality: 6

Cultivation: field crops and orchards

Cisterns: 30

Nearest water source: spring (‘Ain el-Far‘ah, no. 85), 9 km distant

Nearest road: Meithalun – Kfer (C10), 1 km distant

Visibility: 4

July 8, 1979, Feb. 9, 1985, 78 shards

A large ruin on an elongated ridge, some 0.6 km northeast of the village of Sir. Steep slopes descend from the site downward into Wadi Suweid.

The higher part of the ruin is flat, with four steps descending from it to the north. Most of the settlement houses are located on these steps, with five well-preserved structures on the top. These are built of large, hewn stones, and their measurements are 5x8 m. The walls stand to five courses of stones, and a limestone pillar section was found Nearby. Caves, cisterns and quarries are nearby. Some of the cisterns had two or more openings.

The site is a large village from the Roman-Byzantine period, presumably *Azilin*, a town from the *Rehov* inscription.

Pottery: ER – 20%; LR – 20%; Byz – 50%; EM – 10%.

Coin find: Nine, from the Roman and Byzantine periods, and see appendix.

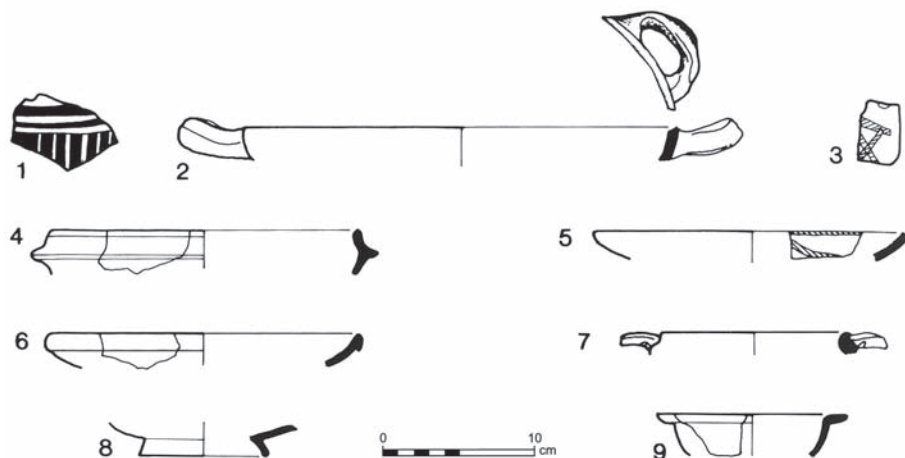
Identification: Probably *Azilin*, line 27 of *Rehov* inscription, and see chapter three.

Previous surveys: None.

Bibliography: Zussman 1981, 167; Zertal 1992, 71 (regarding identification).



60. The Roman-Byzantine village of el-Khirbeh (ez-Zard) from a bird's eye view, looking east. The village is on the ridge, where light-colored sections are seen. The outer houses of Sir are at right. 1993.



61. Pottery from el-Khirbeh (ez-Zard), nos. 4, 9 – LR; 2-3, 5, 7 – Byz; 1 – EM. 1. Jar, Wh on bl dec; 2. 'Frying pan', lt br; 3. Dec, br on wh; 4. Bowl, Eastern Sigilata, red slip and burnish; 5. Bowl, br with gray dec; 6. Bowl, lt pk, Rom; 7. CP, bl; 8. Bowl, pk/bl, Rom; 9. Small bowl, pk/gray.



Site 15: 18 – 19/27/1

Kfer (SWP map: El-Kufair)

Israel grid: 1823 1977

UTM grid: 7202 5849

Elevation: 426 m a.s.l., 20 m a.s.a.

Name type: on map, but not as historical site

Site type: small Arab village

Area: 5 dunams (1.25 acres)

Topography: valley and ridge

Rock type: alluvium cover

Soil type: alluvium; quality: 8

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 11

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain Ginai, no. 35), 8 km distant

Nearest road: Far'ah – Qabatiyeh junction (B5), passes by site

Visibility: 5

Jan. 19, 1985, 22 shards

A village on a low ridge on the western Zebabdeh Valley. The road from Shechem to the Dothan Valley passes through the village, where the road to Sir branches off from it to the west.

The small village, with five inhabited houses now, is on top of an ancient ruin. Remains of walls, cisterns and hewn installations marks this site.

Pottery: Byz – 20%; EM – 50%;

MA – 20%; Ott – 10%.

In 1596 15 families and six single people were in the village, all Moslems. Guérin (1870) notes the Thabor oak tree reserve in the area. During the visit of the SWP (1874) the place was deserted. During our

visit the village, with its poorly built buildings, was still deserted (except the mosque).

Previous surveys: none.

Bibliography: SWP II, 243; Guérin 1969 (IV), 353-354; Hutteroth and Abd el-Fatah 1977, 127.



Site 16: 18 – 19/47/1

Mughur Abu Rishi

Israel grid: 1842 1975

UTM grid: 7222 5841

Elevation: 370 m a.s.l., 30 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: small ruin

Area: 2.4 dunams (0.5 acre)

Topography: valley and ravine

Rock type: alluvium cover

Soil type: alluvium; quality: 8

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain el-Far'ah, no. 85), 10 km distant

Nearest road: Far'ah – Qabatiyeh junction (B5), 1.5 km distant

Visibility: 1

Oct. 26, 1980, 60 shards and 24 flint items

* * *

A site in a small inner valley, in the center of Zebabdeh Valley.

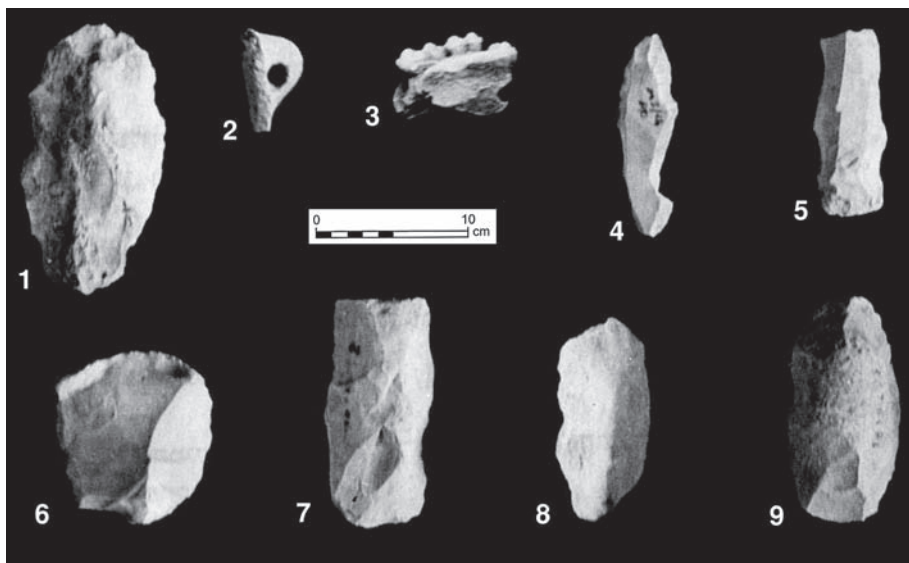
There is here an elevated low range descending into the plain, with terraces on it, 6-8 m high. No remnants of buildings were detected, but a small mound indicates ruined houses. A large cave west

of the site may have been used for dwelling.

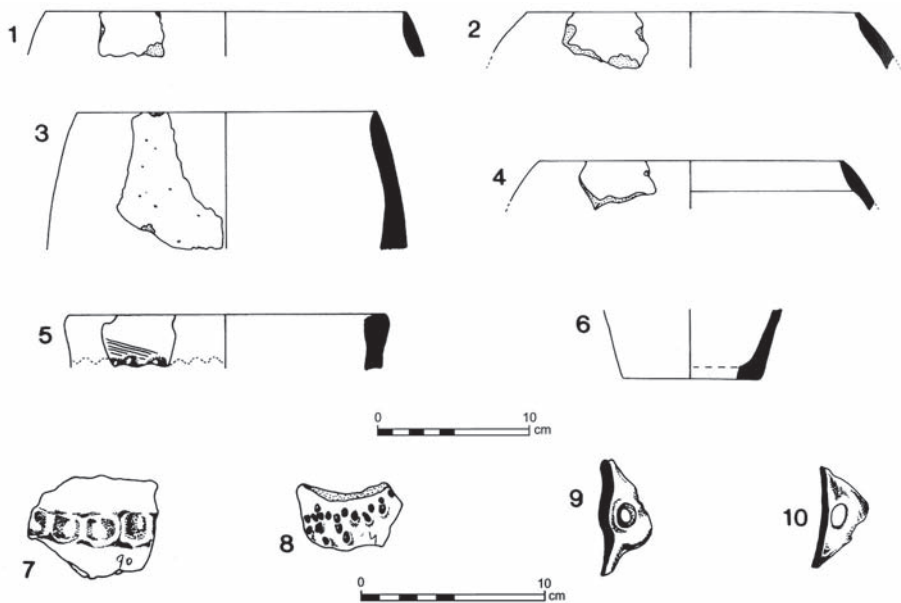
Pottery: Chal – 100%.

Special finds: Many flint finds (adzes, etc.) and basalt vessels from the Ghassulian Chalcolithic Period; for flint find see appendix.

Previous surveys: none.



62. Flint adzes and loop handle (no. 2) from the Chalcolithic Period site of Mughur Abu Rishi (no. 3 – a jaw and teeth).



63. Pottery from Mughur Abu Rishi, all Chal: 1-4. Bowls and HM jars, br and yel; 5. Bowl, br; 6. Bowl base, lt; 7-10. Rope and pierced dec, loop handles, yel.

Site 17: 18 – 19/47/2

Khirbet Hamdun

Israel grid: 1849 1975

UTM grid: 7226 5841

Elevation: 420 m a.s.l., l.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: shard scatter

Area: 2.5 dunams (0.6 acre)

Topography: valley and ridge

Rock type: alluvium cover

Soil type: alluvium; quality: 8

Cultivation: orchards

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: spring (‘Ain el-Far‘ah, no. 85), 10 km distant

Nearest road: Salhab – Beth Shean junction (B7), 1.5 km distant

Visibility: 3

Oct. 15, 1980, 33 shards

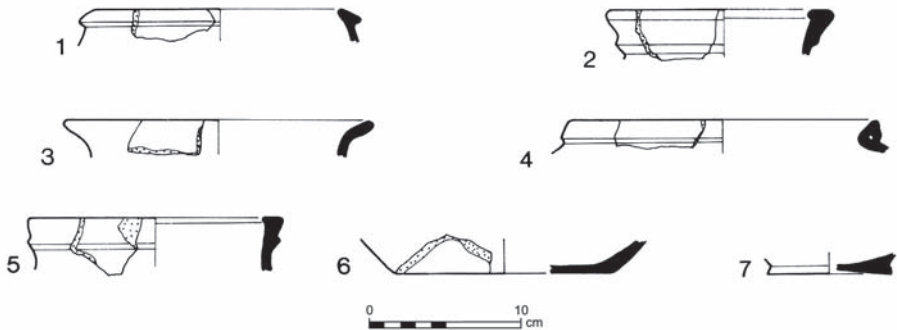
A small site on a wide ridge in Zebabdeh Valley, 1 km west of Kh. Qrud.

On the ridge is a medium sized shard scatter, without building remnants. It appears that the structures

were dismantled and their stones transported to Kh. Qrud, nearby.

Pottery: MBA I – 5%; MBA IIB – 95%.

Previous surveys: none.



64. Pottery from Kh. Hamdun in the Zebabdeh Valley, nos. 3, 6 – MBA I; the rest from MBA IIB: 1-2. Jars, yel; 3. Jar, lt; 4. CP, dk br; 5. Jar, yel; 6. Jar base, yel; 7. Bowl base, gray.

Site 18: 18 – 19/57/1

Khirbet Qrud

(also named by locals Kh. Bismillah er-Rahman er-Rahim)

Israel grid: 1857 1973

UTM grid: 7238 5843

Elevation: 480 m a.s.l., 3 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: small ruin

Area: 2.5 dunams (0.6 acre)

Topography: valley

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: alluvium; quality: 8

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: 8

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain el-Far'ah, no. 85), 10 km distant

Nearest road: Salhab – Beth Shean junction (B7), 1 km distant

Visibility: 5

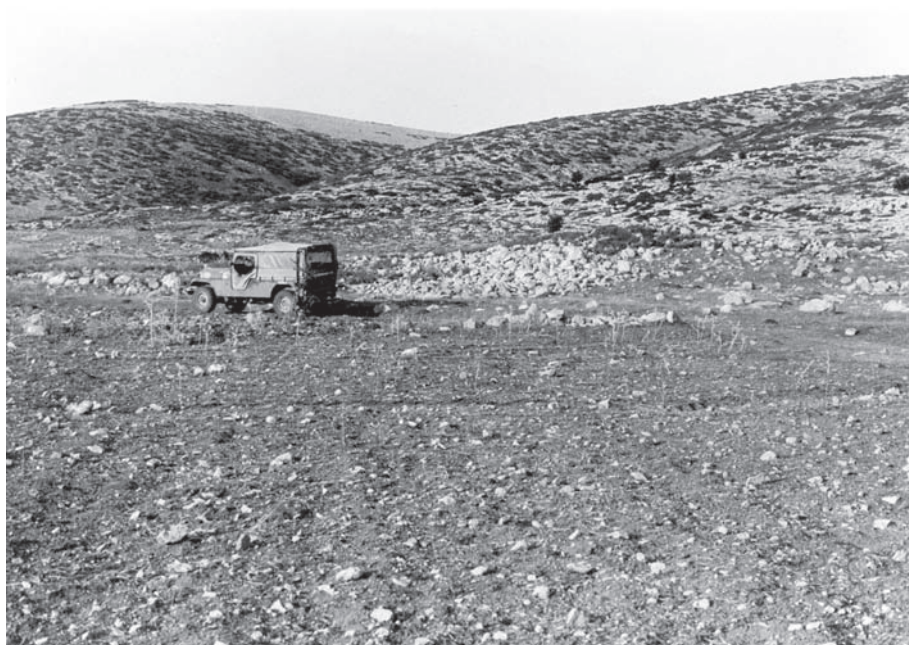
Oct. 15, 1980; Nov. 30, 1980, 77 shards

* * *

A site on the lower, eastern margins of Zebabdeh Valley. Slightly elevated, it is a part of a low, rocky ridge in the foothills of Ras es-Salmeh. There is a fine view of Zebabdeh

Valley from here.

The core of the site is a rectangular courtyard some 15x25 m in size, now a large depression surrounded by built-up walls. The wall, which



65. Kh. Qrud on the edge of Zebabdeh Valley, seen from the west. Remains of the fortification are seen behind the jeep, with Ras es-Salmeh in the background. Winter 1988.

resembles a rampart, was preserved in the south and east but not in the north. The possible entrance seems to be in the western wall. West of the site are three especially large, hewn cisterns, with hewn installations nearby. One of them may have once been a spring that has dried up.

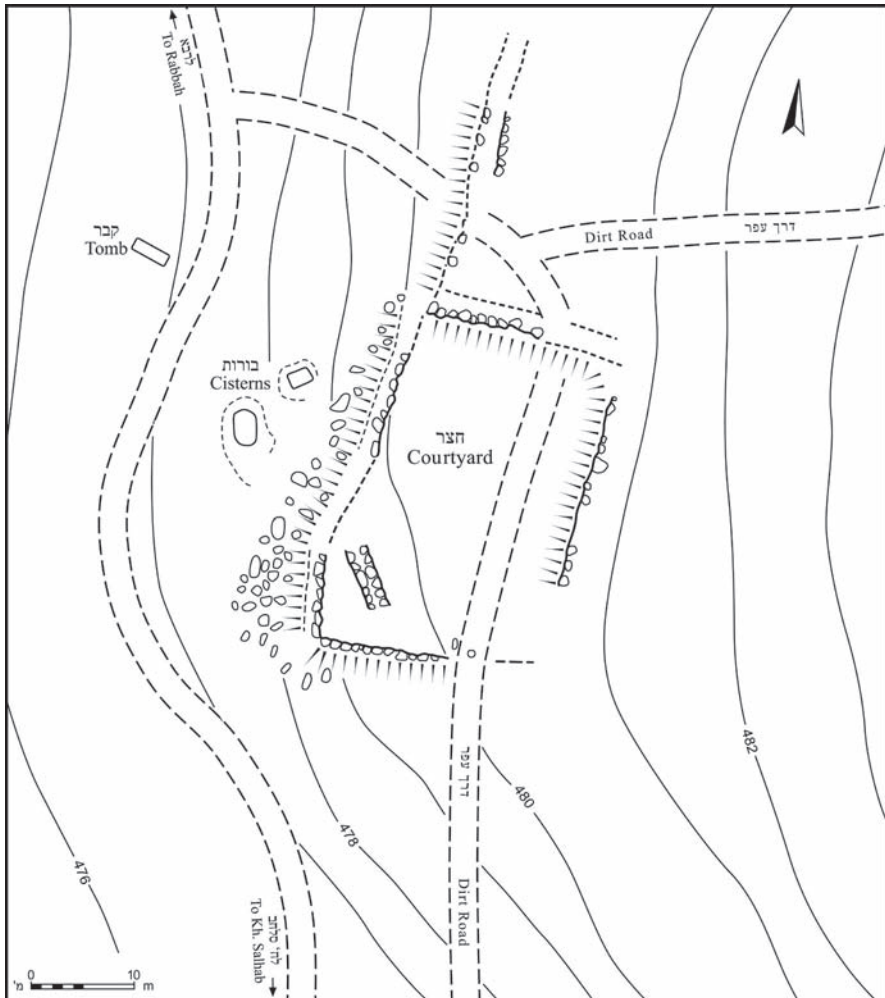
Judging by its shape, the place

might have been a fortress or fortified place during Iron Age III (Assyrian Period).

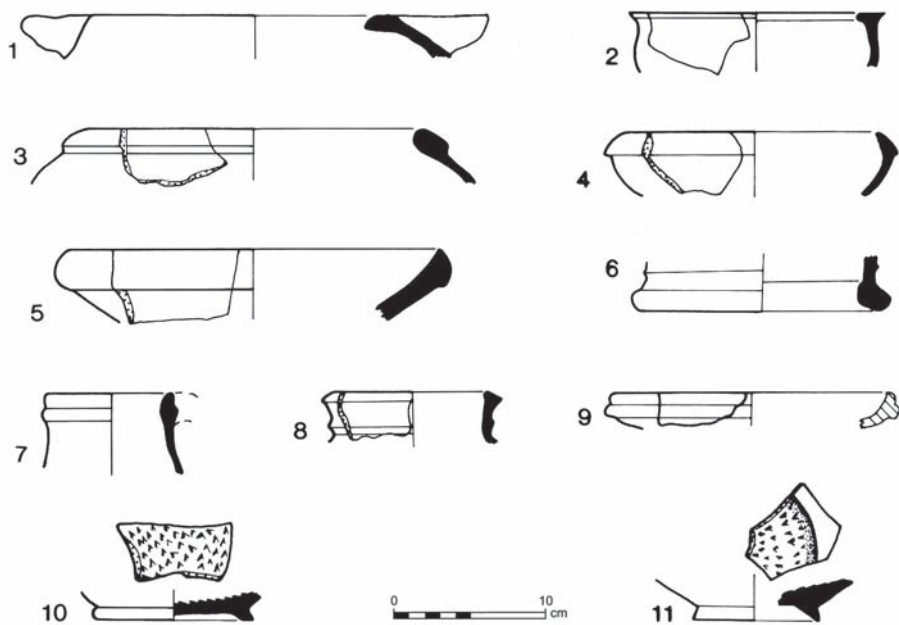
Pottery: MBA I – 10%; MBA IIB – 10%; IrA II – 5%; IrA III – 65%; Hel – 5%; MA – 5%.

Special find: Six fragments of bowls with wedge decoration.

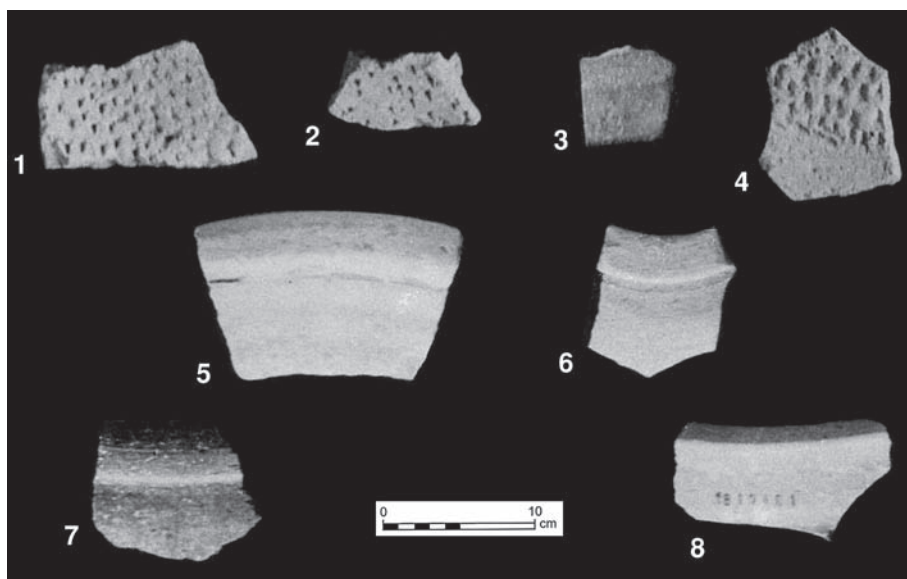
Previous surveys: none.



66. Plan of the fortified site at Kh. Qrud. Note the depression, which is the site's center.



67. Pottery from Kh. Qrud: nos. 1-4, 7-8, 10-11 – IrA III; 5-6 – Per: 1. HM jar, br; 2. Bowl, br; 3. Crater-HM jar, dk; 4. Bowl, yel; 5. Bowl, yel; 6. ‘Mortaria’ base, yel; 7-8. Jars, orange/gray; 9. Dec bowl, basalt; 10-11. Bowls with wedge dec, orange/bl.



68. Photos of pottery from the site: 1-4. Wedge dec on bowls; 5. ‘Mortaria’ rim; 6-7. HM jar rims; 8. Bowl.

Site 19: 17 – 19/96/1

ed-Der

Israel grid: 1796 1969

UTM grid: 7177 5835

Elevation: 445 m a.s.l., 15 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: shard scatter

Area: 0.5 dunam (0.125 acre)

Topography: ridge

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa; quality: 8

Cultivation: orchards

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain Jerbah, no. 49), 5 km distant

Nearest road: Meithalun – Kfer (C10), 1 km distant

Visibility: 3

July 8, 1979, 24 shards

* * *

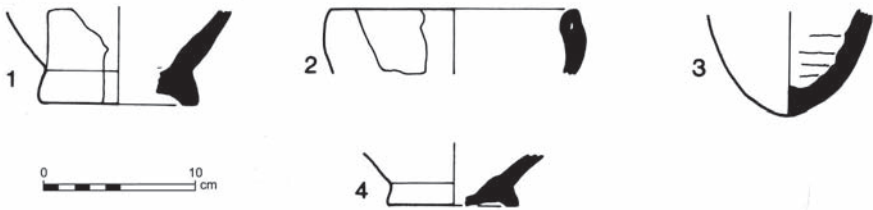
A small site on a ridge, about 0.2 km north of the village of Sir.

Concentrations of Iron Age I potsherds were found with no building remnants. Nearby various quarried places and two caves are located.

Local traditions mention a monastery there, the possible origin of the name (Arabic – 'deir' = monastery).

Pottery: IrA IA-B – 100%.

Previous surveys: none.



69. Pottery from ed-Der, from IrA I: 1. Jar base, br; 2-3. Pythos rim and base, dk br; 4. Bowl base, br.

Site 20: 17 – 19/96/3

Sir (same on SWP map)

Israel grid: 1798 1966

UTM grid: 7179 5833

Elevation: 470 m a.s.l., 30 m a.s.a.

Name type: on map but not as historical site

Site type: Arab village

Area: 5 dunams (1.25 acres)

Topography: ridge edge, valley edge and hilltop

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa; quality: 8

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 35

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain Jerbah, no. 49), 5 km distant

Nearest road: Meithalun – Kfer (C10), passes by site

Visibility: 5

July 8, 1979, 40 shards

* * *

A small village on a flat hilltop in the western part of Zebabdeh Valley (also known as Sahl Sir), near and above the eastern edges of Sanur Valley. A good road leads east-

wards to Kfer, a dirt road goes west to Meithalun, and a path goes north to Meseliyeh.

Steep slopes descend to the north and the east from the village, which



70. An aerial photo of Sir, looking northeast. The tell is in the center of the picture. East of the village are the plains of en-Nkhelat and north, along the ridge, is el-Khirbeh (ez-Zard). Winter 1993.

is connected to the southeast by a saddle. In the center of the village a large, fortified structure marks the core of the Medieval site. Most of the pottery was collected on the northern slope.

Pottery: Per – 5%; ER – 10%; LR – 10%; Byz – 25%; EM – 10%; MA – 20%; Ott – 10%; Mod – 10%.

A Crusader estate named *Casale Syrorum*, whose rights were affirmed in 1165 by Amalrich I, the Crusader king of Jerusalem, was once located here. In 1596 there were 31 family households and four single peo-

ple there, all Moslems. The SWP speaks of a fortified structure, while Guérin mentions a “tomb hewn in rock” and a mosque.

Identification: Presumably identified with *Sir* (line 27 in the *Rehov* inscription); this is confirmed by the findings, and see chapter three.

Previous surveys: Gophna and Porath 1972, no. 58.

Bibliography: SWP II, 228; Guérin 1969 (IV), 353; Beyer 1940, 175; Hutteroth and Abd el-Fatah 1977, 125.



Site 21: 18-19/06/1

en-Nkhelat

Israel grid: 1806 1965

UTM grid: 7185 5833

Elevation: 435 m a.s.l., 15 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: large ruin

Area: 40 dunams (10 acres)

Topography: ridge edge and valley edge

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa and alluvium;

quality: 8

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain el-Far'ah, no. 85), 10 km distant

Nearest road: Meithalun – Kfer (C10), passes by site

Visibility: 4

July 8, 1979; Feb. 5, 1986, 31 shards

* * *

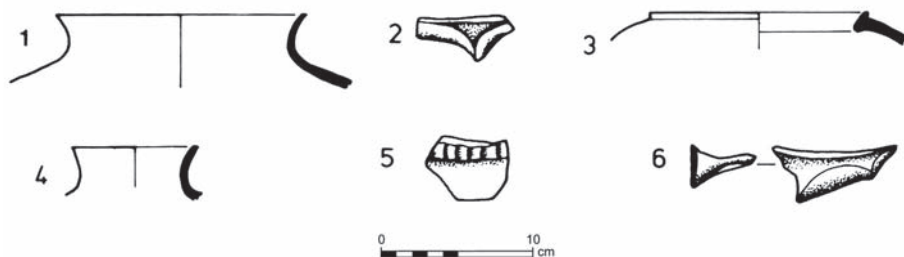
A site on a broad slope in Sahl Sir, 1 km east of the village of Sir. The Kfer - Sir asphalt road passes nearby and south of the site.

At the upper part of the site four large 'courtyards' are located, separated from each other by stone ramparts, 5 m wide and 2 m high. At

the top of the slope, in the west, are several large cairns. On the surface is a sparse shard scatter from the Middle Bronze Age I. We were unable to determine the relationship between the ramparts and courtyards and the original site.

Pottery: MBA I – 100%.

Previous surveys: none.



71. Pottery from en-Nkhelat (all MBA I): 1, 4. Jars, yel; 2, 6. Folded edge handles, yel; 3. HM jar with 'stepped' rim, yel; 5. Rope dec.



72. Aerial view of en-Nkhelat, looking northeast. The site is in the 'courtyards', in the center of the photo; the connection between the site and the stone ramparts is unclear. Winter 1993.



73. View to the west of the MBA I site of en-Nkhelat, located in the flat ‘courtyards’ on the horizontal range shown in the photo. At left is the road to Sir. 1984.



Site 22: 18-19/35/1

‘Aqabah (on SWP map: Aqabeh)

Israel grid: 1831 1952

UTM grid: 7209 5819

Elevation: 517 m a.s.l., l.s.a.

Name type: on map, but not as historical site

Site type: Arab village

Area: 25 dunams (6.25 acres)

Topography: valley edge and slope

Rock type: ‘Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa and alluvium;

quality: 8

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 35

Nearest water source: spring (‘Ain el-Far‘ah, no. 85), 8 km distant

Nearest road: Fa‘rah – Qabatiyeh junction (B5), passes by site

Visibility: 4

July 26, 1979, 39 shards

A village in the southwestern part of Zebabdeh Valley, in the foothills of Ras Aqr‘ah. A shallow ravine separates the village from the valley

plain.

The ancient core of the village is located above this ravine, through

which passes the main Qabatiyeh – Tubas – Shechem road.

In the center of the village is a small, ancient core with a mosque and a number of old houses. Most of the ancient shards were collected in this area and the central ravine.

Pottery: Per – 20%; Hel – 10%; Byz – 30%; EM – 10%; MA – 10%; Ott – 10%; Mod – 10%.

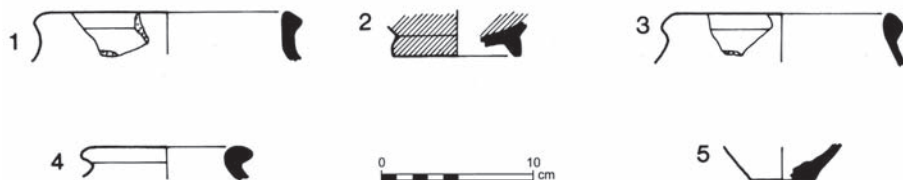
In the 1596 census, 22 families and five single people lived in the village, all Moslems. Guérin visited

the site and noted the dilapidated houses and the mosque to their east.

Possible identification with *Iqbin*, a 'permitted' town in the region of Sebastiyeh (*Rehov* inscription), and see chapter three (But see also site no. 84 – Kh. 'Aqabeh.)

Previous surveys: none.

Bibliography: SWP II, 227; Guérin 1969 (IV), 354; Hutteroth and Abd el-Fatah 1977, 125; Zussman 1981, 166 (regarding identification).



74. Shards from the village of 'Aqabah: 1. Bowl, yel, Byz; 2. Jug, br slip, MA; 3-4. Jars, gray, Per; 5. Jug, lt, Hel.

Site 23: 18-19/55/1

Khirbet Salhab (SWP map: Kh. es-Selhab)

Israel grid: 1853 1957

UTM grid: 7233 5824

Elevation: 430 m a.s.l., 10 m a.s.a.

Name type: on map as historical site

Site type: tell

Area: 15 dunams (3.75 acres)

Topography: hilltop and valley

Rock type: alluvium cover

Soil type: alluvium; quality: 9

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 30

Nearest water source: spring (‘Ain el-Far‘ah, no. 85), 10 km distant

Nearest road: Salhab – Beth Shean junction (B7), passes by site

Visibility: 4

Nov. 30, 1980; Feb. 2, 1987; 46 shards

* * *

A small tell in the southeastern part of Zebabdeh Valley, near the road from Tubas to Kh. Ibziq. It is located on a low, natural hill with a good view of the southern valley.

Three modern houses stand on the western part of the tell, with a considerable concentration of cis-

terns and quarried places nearby. The northern slopes are relatively steep, with large scatters of shards dating up to the Roman period. There are also foundations and walls from the Roman-Byzantine period all over the tell, with few cisterns and quarried places.



75. The tell of Kh. Salhab, looking north. The tell rises up from the plain of Zebabdeh Valley. In front of the tell is the Jordanian anti tank barrier of 1967. Apparently the Biblical *Bezeq* of I Samuel 11:8 can be identified here. 1987.

Pottery: IrA IA – 3%; IrA II – 2%; Per – 5%; ER – 15%; LR – 15%; Byz – 20%; EM – 10%; MA – 15%; Ott – 15%.

Special finds: Pottery handles with indentations and ‘face’ decorations, all dated to Iron Age I.

In 1596 eight families and two single people, all Moslems, lived here.

Identification: With Biblical *Bezeq* (I Samuel 11:8), where Saul has

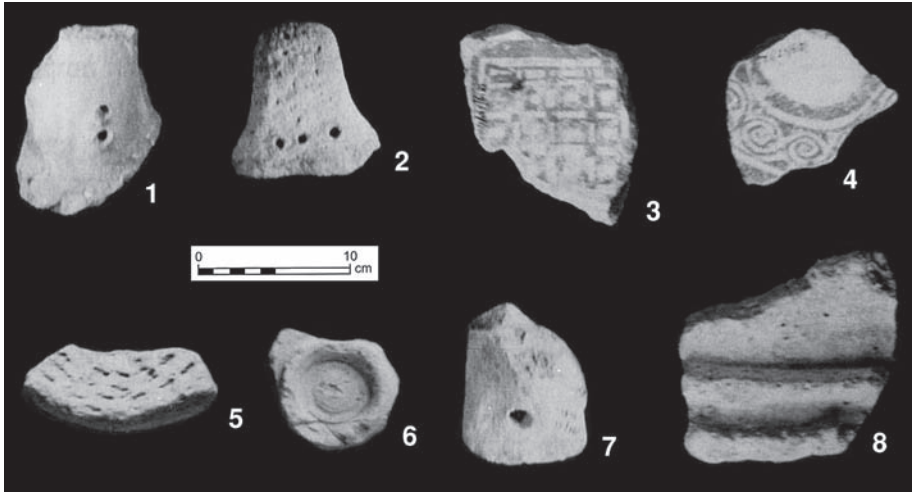
gathered his army to save *Jabesh Gilead*. Another possible identification is with *Palga Deshlaf* from the *Rehov* inscription, and see chapter three.

Previous surveys: Gophna and Porath 1972, no. 65.

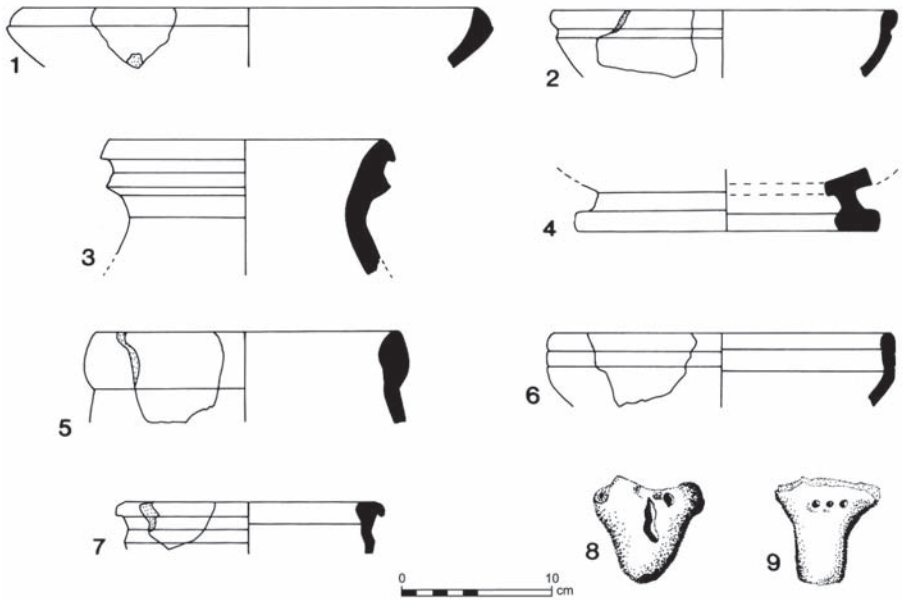
Bibliography: SWP II, 240; Guérin 1969 (IV), 354-355; Avi-Yonah 1966, 152; 1976, 92; Hutteroth and Abd el-Fatah 1977, 129; Zussman 1981, 167.



76. The south Zebabdeh Valley, Ras es-Salmeh and Kh. Salhab, looking northeast. The tell is in the heart of the valley, with anti-tank barrier (left). *Bezeq* (Ibziq) Pass is in the right side. The area coincide the traditions of I Samuel 11:8 (Saul campaign to *Jabesh Gilead*). Winter 1987.



77. Shards from Kh. Salhab: 1-2. Handles with indentation dec, IrA I; 3-4. Dec bowls, violet on wh, MA (Mameluk); 5. Bowl with wedge dec, IrA III; 6. Base, Hel; 7. Handle with indentation dec, IrA I; 8. 'Stepped' jar, "Eynun family", IrA I.



78. Shards from Kh. Salhab: 1. Bowl, yel; 2. Bowl, br, IrA II; 3. Jar, dk br, IrA IA ('Eynun'); 4. Bowl, yel; 5. Pythos, br, IrA I; 6. Bowl, lt, ER; 7. Bowl, lt br, Rom; 8. Handle with 'human face', IrA I; 9. Handle with indentation dec, IrA I.

CHAPTER FIVE

RAS ES-SALMEH

LANDSCAPE UNIT 13



A ruined tower near the village of Rabbah
From: The second volume of the *Survey of Western Palestine*, p. 244

Site 24: 18 – 20/71/1

Abu Tahah

Israel grid: 1876 2015

UTM grid: 7254 5883

Elevation: 190 m a.s.l., l.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: small farm

Area: 1 dunam (0.25 acre)

Topography: slope and ravine

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: Colluvial Alluvial; quality: 6

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 1

Nearest water source: springs (Q'aun Springs, no. 132), 6 km distant

Nearest road: Salhab – Beth Shean junction (B7), 3 km distant

Visibility: 6

Feb. 21, 1986; 81 shards

* * *

A small site in Wadi Shubash, where Wadi Tahah connects with the former.

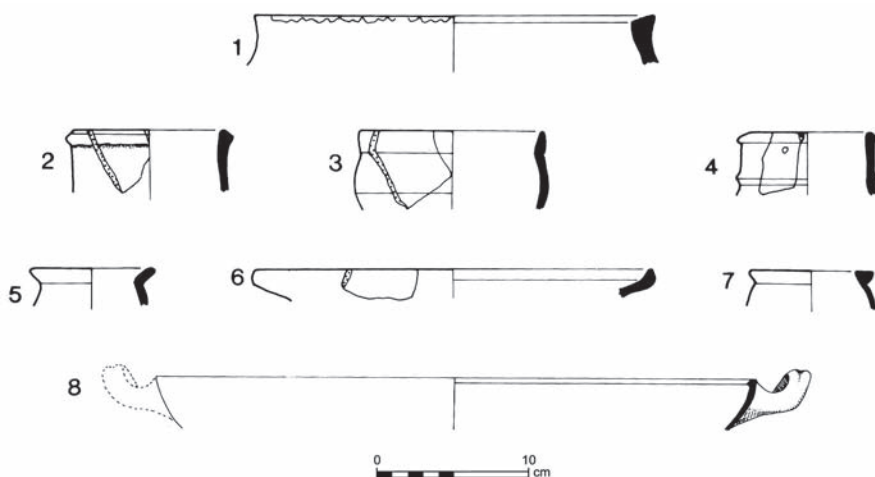
There is a courtyard here, about 10x25 m in size. Above on the slope there is a structure 4x8 m in

size, with a cistern nearby.

This is a small farm with its various installations.

Pottery: Byz – 50%; EM – 40%; MA – 10%.

Previous surveys: none.



79. Shards from Abu Tahah: 1. Crater, dk, EM; 2. Jar, dk, Byz; 3. Bowl, yel, EM; 4-5. Jar and jug, Byz; 6. Bowl, bl, MA; 7. Jug, Byz; 8. 'Frying pan', br, Byz.

Site 25: 19 – 20/01/1

el-Beyaz (A)

Israel grid: 1902 2015

UTM grid: 7280 5884

Elevation: 220 m a.s.l.; 80 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: small settlement with structural remnants

Area: 4 dunams (1 acre)

Topography: slope

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: Colluvial Alluvial; quality: 3

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: springs (Q'aun Springs, no. 132), 2 km distant

Nearest road: Salhab – Beth Shean junction (B7), passes by site

Visibility: 6

Feb. 28, 1986; 66 shards

* * *

A site on a high slope, about 2 km west of the exit of Wadi Shubash to the Beth Shean Valley.

The place is located on a moun-

tain range called Ras el-Ahmar, north of Wadi Shubash. Three long terraces are built along the top of the slope. Nearby are patches of



80. The Middle Bronze Age I site of el-Beyaz (A), looking west. It is located on the top of the light-colored ridge, where the structures are located (photo – center). At left, beyond the ridge, deep Wadi Shubash is visible. Winter 1986.

cultivated land and remains of buildings, with shards and flint tools. The building stones are concentrated in two large piles with a large amount of potshards in their

vicinity. The relatively good preservation is due to the remoteness and high location of the site.

Pottery: MBA I – 100%.

Previous surveys: none.



Site 26: 19 – 20/01/2

el-Beyaz (B)

Israel grid: 1903 2011

UTM grid: 7281 5884

Elevation: 100 m a.s.l.; 20 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: small farm

Area: 1 dunam (0.25 acre)

Topography: ridge

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa; quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: springs (Q'aun Springs, no. 132), 2 km distant

Nearest road: Salhab – Beth Shean junction (B7), 1 km distant

Visibility: 6

Feb. 28, 1986; 39 shards

* * *

A farm complex on a broad ridge, descending from 'Iraq el-Hamam into Wadi Shubash.

The farm includes a large courtyard (about 8x25 m), with a surrounding wall 1 m wide, built of large, hewn stones. In this yard

there is a small construction about 3x5 m in size with a cistern nearby. The latter is also built of hewn stones.

Pottery: Byz – 100%.

Previous surveys: None.

Site 27: 19 – 20/21/1

Jelamet Hamul

Israel grid: 1922 2018

UTM grid: 7301 5885

Elevation: 65 m a.s.l.; l.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: structure

Area: 0.3 dunam (0.12 acre)

Topography: ridge

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: Colluvia Alluvial; quality: 3

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: springs (Q'aun Springs, no. 132), 2 km distant

Nearest road: Salhab – Beth Shean junction (B7), 0.5 km distant

Visibility: 5

Mar. 13, 1986; 20 shards

* * *

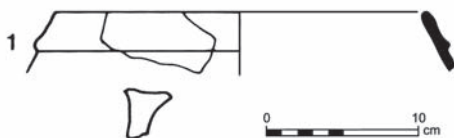
A site on a broad, rocky hillock on the southwestern edge of Beth Shean Valley, east of the hilly mass of 'Iraq el-Hamam.

In the center of the site there is a rectangular structure measuring 7x9 m in size and divided into rooms. Only one course of the foundations

has survived, built of large and medium sized field stones. This building was probably of the 'four room house' type, with few shards scattered around. A grinding stone was also found.

Pottery: IrA I – 100%.

Previous surveys: none.



81. CP from IrA I, dk br, Jelamet Hamul.

Site 28: 18 – 20/30/2

en-Naqb

Israel grid: 1839 2005

UTM grid: 7218 5872

Elevation: 380 m a.s.l.; 40 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: medium sized ruin

Area: 7 dunams (1.75 acres)

Topography: slope and ravine

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa and alluvium;
quality: 6

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: springs (Q'aun
Springs, no. 132), 11 km distantNearest road: Far'ah – Qabatiyeh
junction (B5), 5 km distant

Visibility: 1

Dec. 28, 1980; 75 shards and flint
tools

* * *

A large site on a steep slope descending into Wadi Shubash. It is located near the sharp twists of the wadi, where it joins Wadi Khudeirat. In the spot where the wadis join there is a small internal valley.

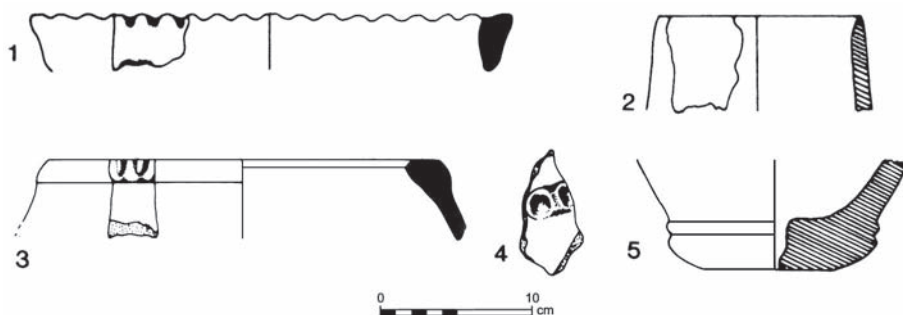
The place was founded over terraces built on the steep slope. In the upper part there are a few potshards

and piles of cleared stones. No structures were found, but building stones are scattered along the terraces.

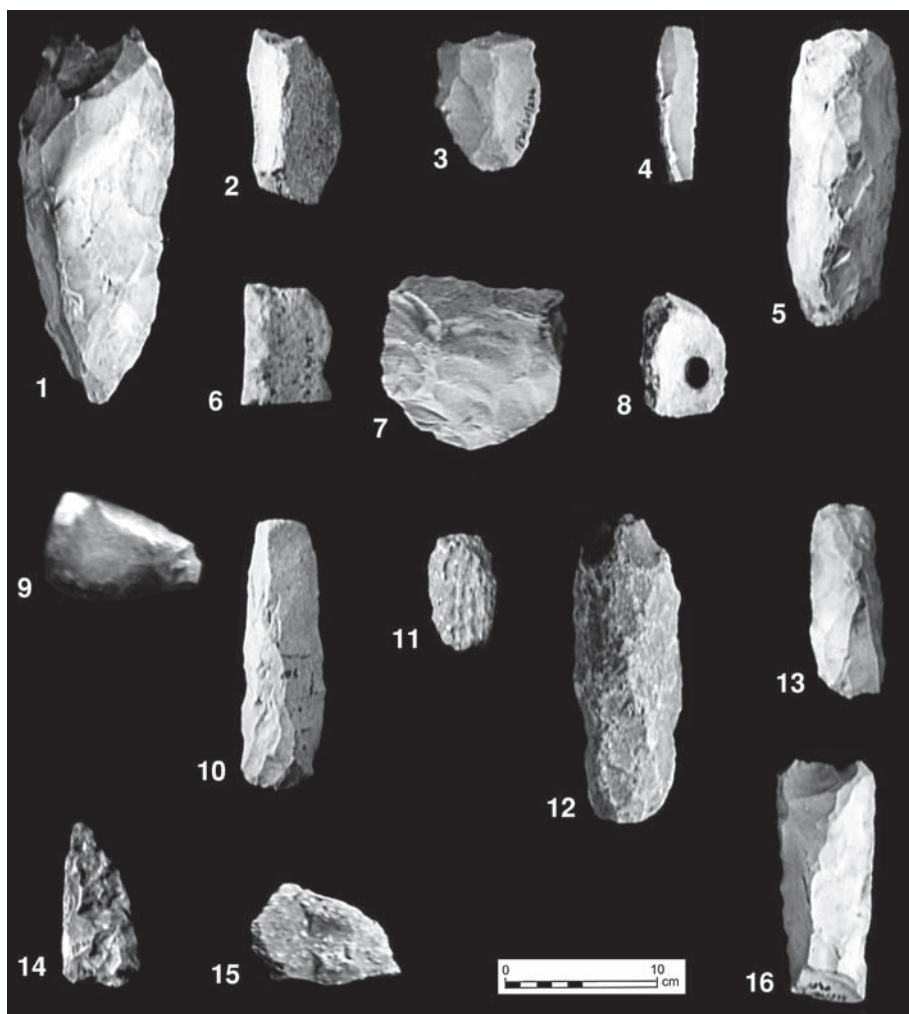
A large number of adzes from the Chalcolithic period was discerned.

Pottery and flint: Chal – 100%.

Previous surveys: none.



82. Pottery from en-Naqb, all Chal: 1. Crater, br; 2, 5. Basalt vessels; 3. Dec HM jar, br; 4. Rope dec, lt br.



83. Flint tools, stone tools and pottery fragments from the Chalcolithic Period site of en-Naqb.

Site 29: 18 – 20/40/1

el-Mabhashiyyeh

Israel grid: 1847 2005

UTM grid: 7228 5870

Elevation: 315 m a.s.l.; 40 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: small ruin

Area: 4.9 dunams (1.2 acres)

Topography: slope

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa; quality: 7

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: springs (Q'aun Springs, no. 132), 9 km distant

Nearest road: Far'ah – Qabatiyeh junction (B5), 3.5 km distant

Visibility: 1

Jan. 18, 1985; 40 shards and 43 flint items

A small site on a steep slope north of Wadi el-Balad, about 2 km east of Tilfit.

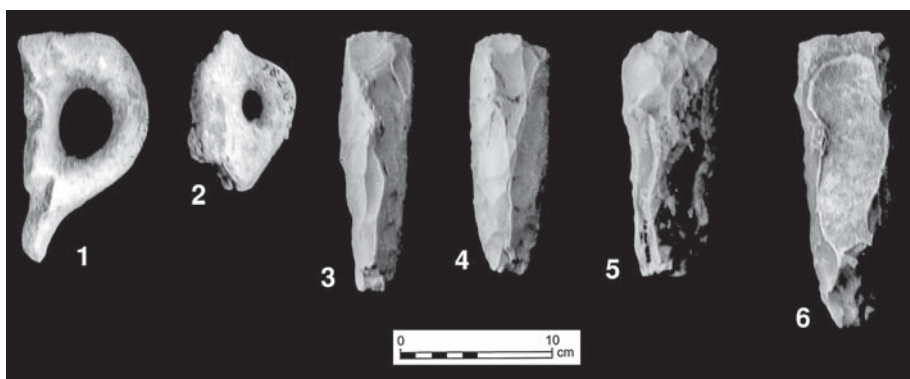
There are several walls *in situ*, on the slope and on the plain and steps. In the cultivated area on the slope many flint tools and shards were collected, with six or seven cave openings on the upper slope, some artificial.

This site is located in a wind protected ravine, apparently connected with the en-Naqb site (site 28).

Pottery and flint find: Ghassulian Chal – 100%.

Special find: especially well made flint tools and axes, and see appendix.

Previous surveys: none.



84. Loop handles (1-2) and flint adzes (3-6) from the Chalcolithic site of el-Mabhashiyyeh.

Site 30: 18 – 20/50/1

Wadi el-Balad

Israel grid: 1858 2004

UTM grid: 7238 5872

Elevation: 410 m a.s.l.; l.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: small site

Area: 1.5 dunams (0.4 acre)

Topography: valley edge

Rock type: 'Avdat formation

Soil type: Colluvia Alluvial; quality: 8

Cultivation: orchards

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: springs (Q'aun Springs, no. 132), 8 km distant

Nearest road: Salhab – Beth Shean junction (B7), 3.5 km distant

Visibility: 1

Jan. 25, 1986; 71 shards

A small site in a ravine, 1 km north

of the village of Rabbah. Here is the meeting point of Wadi el-Balad with a ravine descending from Merah el-Kharrubeh.

The site is located at the bottom of a rocky ridge, close to a broad ravine with good agricultural land nearby. An olive orchard now stands there, where two cleared courtyards, terraces, large building stones and piles of cleared stones are found. In the orchard there is

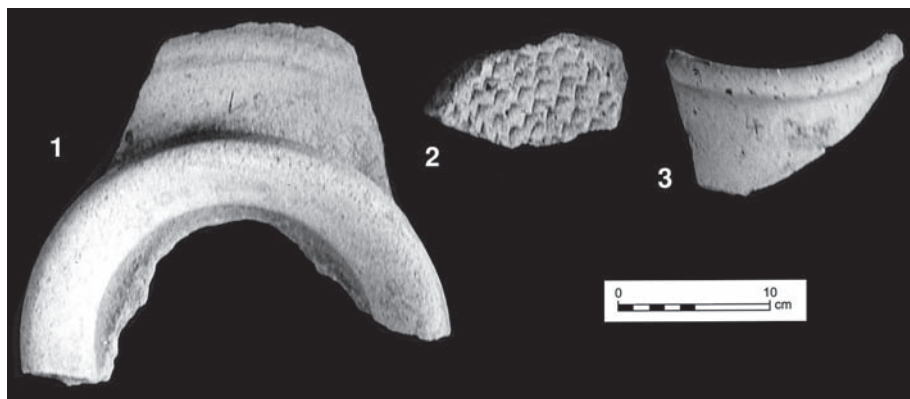
light colored, chalky material with a wealth of shards.

A farm or small village, founded in the Iron Age II-III and existing primarily in the Persian Period, was here.

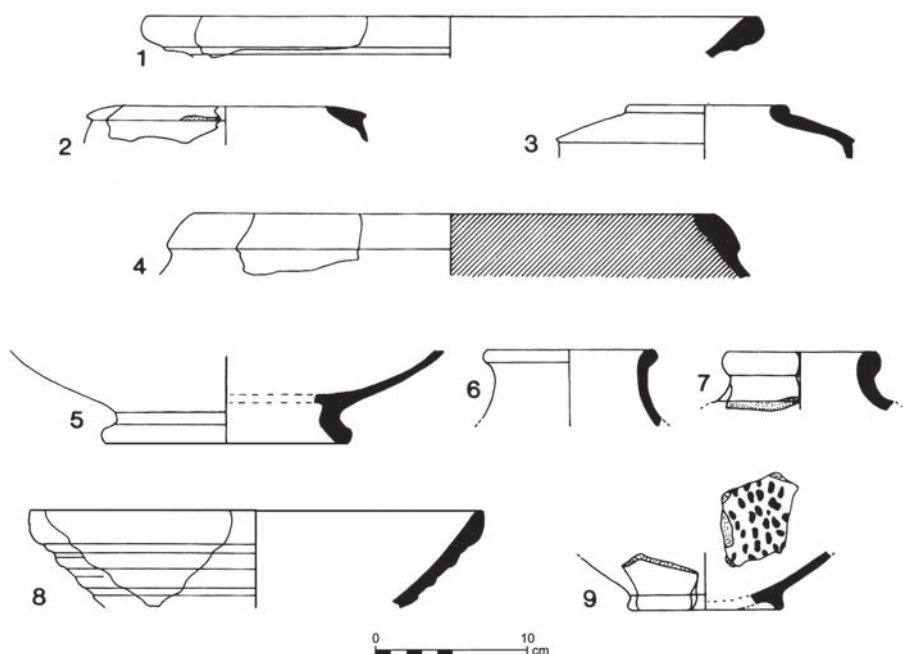
Pottery: IrA II – 5%; IrA III – 10%; Per – 85%.

Special find: Two fragments of bowls with wedge decoration.

Previous surveys: none.



85. Pottery from Wadi el-Balad: 1. 'Mortaria' bowl, Per; 2. Bowl with wedge dec, IrA III; 3. Jar, Per.



86. Pottery from Wadi el-Balad: 1. Bowl, gray, Per; 2. HM jar, gray/orange, IrA III; 3. Jar-HM jar, gray, IrA II-III; 4. Crater, slip inside, IrA II-III; 5. Bowl, yel, Per; 6-7. Jars, yel, IrA III – Per; 8. Bowl, gray, Per; 9. Bowl with wedge dec, gray/orange, IrA III.



Site 31: 18 – 20/90/1

‘Iraq el-Hamam (Lower)

Israel grid: 1897 2007

UTM grid: 7273 5874

Elevation: 428 m a.s.l., 60 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: small site

Area: 1 dunam (0.25 acre)

Topography: high ridge

Rock type: ‘Avdat formation

Soil type: terra rossa; quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: springs (Q‘aun Springs, no. 132), 4 km distant

Nearest road: Salhab – Beth Shean junction (B7), passes by site

Visibility: 4

Feb. 21, 1986; Jul. 15, 2006; 41 shards and 51 flint items

A small site on a high ridge west of ‘Iraq el-Hamam. It is close to a crossroads, with roads leading

to *Bezeq* Valley (Sahl Ibziq), Wadi Shubash and the Beth Shean Valley.



87. The Chalcolithic Period site of 'Iraq el-Hamam, looking southwest from Wadi Shubash. The remains are on the hilltop, right hand of the solitary tree. Winter 1986.



88. Flint and stone tools from the Chalcolithic Period site of 'Iraq el-Hamam.

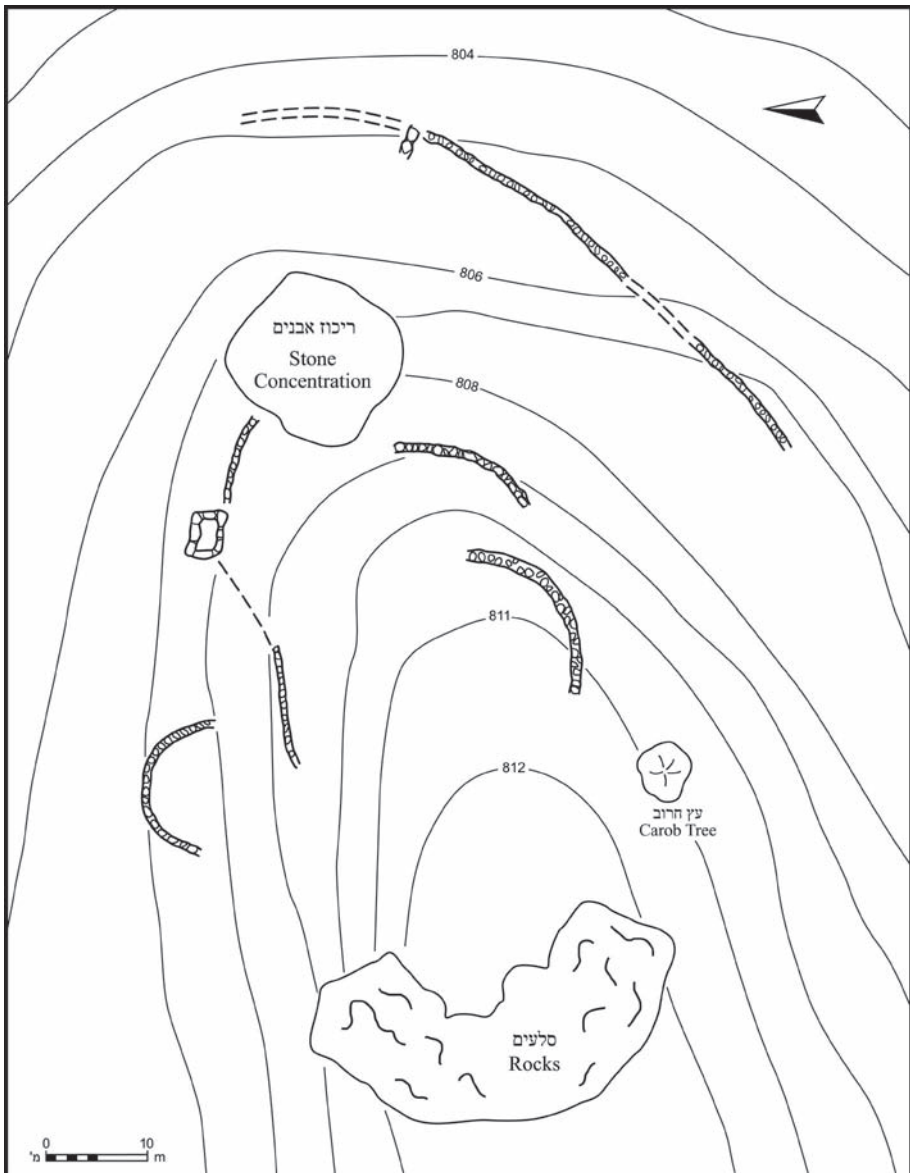
Several stone piles are in the area, with two structure walls and terraces. Medium sized amounts of shards and flint tools, especially adzes, are scattered around.

Above the hilltop, some 0.2 km

to the west, there is a small farm dated to the Byzantine period.

Pottery and flint: Chal – 50%; Byz – 50%. For flint find see appendix.

Previous surveys: none.



89. Plan of the site at 'Iraq el-Hamam (lower).